Burnt Into My Skin

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/41648469.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Additional Tags:
soul mark, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Friends to Lovers, Getting to Know Each Other, bartender catra, Slice of Life, Fluff and Angst, Fluff and Humor, Falling In Love, Love Confessions, Requited Love, Angst with a Happy Ending, Alternate Universe - Soulmates

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by ResFlower

Summary

"Are you with your soulmate? Or are you waiting around for them like half the world?" Adora uses air quotes to emphasize Catra's words. Adora can feel her palms sweat, thinking of how she'll feel if Catra says she has found her other half.

Catra shrugs, a picture of carelessness. "Nah. I haven't thought about my soul mark since it disappeared off me." The blasé way she says it makes Adora feel like that wasn't the whole truth.

Adora doesn't press. "It aches sometimes. Feels empty, without the soul mark." Adora admits in a quiet whisper staring down at the bar top. Catra absentmindedly rubs her left shoulder.

Adora looks up at Catra. Both of Catra's hands press down on the bar top. Adora takes a chance and slowly slides her hand next to Catra's, only their pinkies touching. The small touch feels like it vibrates through Adora's body.

"But I don't ache when I'm here with you." Adora shrugs apologetically like she knows she shouldn't say something so forward to a woman who is just trying to do her job.

OR

Adora doesn't find her soulmate by 30 and her soul mark disappears. The next week, she meets a bartender that turns her world on its head. Soul Mark AU.

Notes

Many thanks to both yagirlStatic__ and furiousgold_ for betaing this chapter!

Chapter 1

Chapter Summary

Adora turns 30.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora locks her car door, stepping back into the brisk winter air. She glances at her watch as she takes long strides across the parking lot. *Fuck. Late again* , she thought, picking up her pace. *Glimmer's going to kill me* .

Adora's normally a punctual person, but for once, she's not excited to see Bow and Glimmer. They havent said anything, but she knows a trap when she sees one. This brunch invitation has the makings of an intervention, and she's simply not in the mood for it. So what if she hasnt found her soulmate? Not everyone even had a soulmate, much less found them by the ripe old age of thirty.

She swings open the restaurant door and her gaze falls on her two best friends, sitting at a booth. They are heatedly speaking back and forth until Bow glances up and sees Adora walking towards the booth. He nudges Glimmer sharply and plasters a nervous smile on his face.

"Hey Hey Adora." His voice is high-pitched as he leans his head on his hand trying to act casual. *Trying* being the operative word there.

"Hi." She says simply , taking up the booth seat opposite the couple. Glimmer's eyes are blazing with determination, it makes Adora tense. "Good morning to you both. Glimmer why are you looking at me like you're about to tackle me."

"Because I'm about to tackle you." Bow sends Glimmer a panicked look. "With my words." She amends.

"Glimmer , if this is about soulmates, I'd really rather you didn't." She sighed as she shifted in her seat. The mounting pressure has come from all sides recently, and this week is the absolute worst.

"Adora, your birthday is next week! W e have to talk about it!" Glimmer insists as she opens her menu forcefully. Adora eyes her before perusing her own menu, taking the time to figure out how to best get out of this conversation.

"W ell, we really don't. W e've had this conversation time and again." She knows her best friends are well-meaning but they just didn't get it. Bow and Glimmer found out they were soulmates at five years old. They couldn't possibly imagine what it was like to be in her position. They never would.

"Okay , then what did you have to say about it?" She asked warily . If she couldn't avoid this conversation, she'd just have to get through it. Thankfully she wouldn't be hearing about soulmates from them after next week anyways.

Glimmer opens her mouth, no doubt about to go on a tirade when the waitress appears.

"What can I get you, folks?" She asks cheerily , pen poised on the paper.

Glimmer visibly deflates but puts in her order. The waitress makes quick work of their requests, leaving Adora with the unpleasant conversation once again.

"So, I just think that you should capitalize on this opportunity to find your soulmate." She says in a low measured tone.

Adora eyes her skeptically. "Y ou think I can find my soulmate in *a week* , Glim? When I couldn't find them, whoever they are, for almost

thirty years now?" She asks incredulously .

The waitress brings them their food, but neither Bow nor Glimmer pays her any mind while the plates clatter as they are set down in front of them.

"What if you put your soul mark in one of those government databases?" Bow suggests, buttering his toast enthusiastically .

Adora sighs putting her head in her hand, elbow on the table. "Aren't soulmates supposed to be brought together by fate? I've heard Perfuma's explanation, it' s all very woo." She puts up the weak resistance, she knows her friends just don't see soulmates the way she does.

"Well, sometimes fate needs a push!" He says, eyes looking fondly at his wife.

She gives him an incredulous stare. It's easy for *him* , he met Glimmer in kindergarten and never looked back. "Bow , Im fine, not everyone even *has* a soulmate, you know that." Most people have a soul mark but an unlucky few are born without. And even with her mark, Adora would prefer to go without.

"Yeah, but Adora you have one out there! Someone who' s going to sweep you off your feet I bet." Bow sighs dreamily . "They just need to check out that shoulder."

"Not every soulmate is romantic." Adora reminds him.

Again, it's like they aren't even listening. "We just worry that you're giving up Adora. But there's still time." Glimmer counters.

Adora takes another bite of her pancakes. "I don't get the big deal is all." Soulmates aren't the end all be all of a successful life and sometimes having a soulmate can be worse than being alone. She would know.

Glimmer stares at Adora agape. "Adora, you know you're running out of time!" Glimmer cuts in. Adora shrugs. It's not news that soul marks disappear if you don't find your soulmate by thirty.

"There's no way I'm going to find someone by next week, and that's fine! That doesn't mean I'll never find them. I have plenty of pictures of my soul mark, I'll recognize it if I see it on someone." She keeps to herself that she isn't quite sure if she would walk up to someone if she saw her mark on their shoulder.

"Adora, it's not the same! For one, it becomes so much harder to find your soulmate because your soul mark won't warm when you see them, and they can't see your soul mark." She looks at Bow, eyes softening as they share a sickly lovey-dovey look. "But also, there's the emotional aspect of it you know when you look at your soul mark on your soulmate's skin. It's life-changing."

She looks back at Adora, leaning forward. "I know I was only a kid the first time I saw Bow's mark, but it's my first real memory. I started crying even though I didn't understand why because it was just overwhelming. And Bow saw and comforted me." Her eyes flicker under the table. "When I look at Bow's ankle and I see my mark, it never fails to fill me with unmitigated joy. Real *joy*." She looks into Bow's eyes as she says this, lost in her husband.

Adora rolls her eyes, having seen enough of their moony displays to know that it will last for a bit.

"I don't want you to miss out on that." Glimmer finishes softly.

"I know the soulmate things worked out for you both but that's not what happens for everyone. I've made peace with it."

Bow and Glimmer exchange a look. "I know you've been burned by soulmates before Adora. I respect that." Adora looks away—she knows most people don't feel conflicted about soulmates the way she does.

She understood what people loved about the idea of soulmates—it's romantic to think about meeting the person you know is the one for you. But the downsides are obvious to her given that she's seen them firsthand. Being soulmates is not a guarantee of happily ever after. If that person cheated, or left—or worse, died—you were fucked. Game over. No more true love—just a gaping hole where it used to be.

She knows her friends are well-meaning but misguided. She tries a new tactic to get them to back off. "Let's say I want to find my soulmate, my soul mark will be gone in a week. Don't you think hyping up something I'm bound to lose is cruel?"

Both of her friends look subdued. "Sorry. We'll leave it alone." Glimmer offers.

Too little too late, but Adora will take it. She tries to lighten the mood by changing the subject. "I thought we were supposed to discuss my birthday plans." She offers the out.

Bow takes the lifeline for what it is. "You're right we need to make it the best birthday yet!" He exclaims.

Glimmer starts making a list. "So, it'll be us three, obviously, and if it's kid-friendly we will bring Angel"—

Adora puts down her cutlery to look at Glimmer incredulously. "It wouldn't be a good birthday without my favorite nephew! Angel has to be there!" Adora loves Glimmer and Bow's kid with her whole heart. She honestly can't imagine loving someone as much as she loves him.

"Okay, okay, so the four of us, Scorpia, Perfuma, we can see if Netossa and Spinnerella can make it too."

"What about Mermista and Seahawk?" Adora adds curiously.

"You know you don't have to invite your ex-girlfriend for the sake of being polite."Adora rolls her eyes.

"Glimmer, who even remembers that?"So what, Mermista and Adora dated for a while. Glimmer sends her a hard stare. "Besides, I love Mermista and Seahawk. I want them there for my birthday."

"I just worried, you know, given the significance of the date."Glimmer tries to be delicate, bless her, she really does.

"If your soul mark is going to disappear it might feel weird, you know, to see her when that happens."Bow adds in.

Adora rolls her eyes. "We all know it wasn't serious and we ended on good terms. I wasn't going to stand between Merms and her soul mate, Glim."

She came to terms with her breakup with Mermista a long time ago. Sometimes did she still miss having a partner? Of course, they shared a lot of good things together. But it ran its course and Adora knew it was for the best.

"Okay well, I mean as long as you're sure."Bow eyes her doubtfully.

Glimmer rolls her eyes moving them along. "So basically, all the usual suspects. What do you want to do?"She asks.

Adora moves a piece of pancake around her plate. "I mean can we all just hang out and have dinner? I don't want to make a big deal of it."Adora doesn't really want to go out where a nosy stranger could ask about her soul mark.

"If you let me decorate every flat surface of your house then yes." Glimmer negotiates.

"Sure, deal."Adora gets back to her pancakes as Glimmer and Bow tell her about the search for Angel's new school.

Glimmer isn't kidding when she said she would decorate every available surface of Adora's house. There are gaudy streamers and sparkling signs all over the house screaming thirty.

Bow is making his famous mushroom risotto with braised short ribs, one of Adora's favorite meals. It's too cold to sit on the back patio so they are planning to hang out inside.

She hears a knock on the door. Before she can answer it, Glimmer appears there first, swinging it open and inviting Netossa and Spinerella inside.

"So, Glimmer , how are we going to glam up the place," Spinny asks, looking overjoyed at having a project. Her eyes are roving what's already done, seemingly approving the loud decorations Glimmer has already picked out.

Adora doesn't really mind the decorations, even if she made a point to make a face when Glimmer brought them. It makes her feel loved to have Glimmer fussing over her.

Glimmer points at the section she's already finished. "I'm thinking what we have now is good, but we need more of it." She explains.

"I bet I can hang more streamers than you." Netossa challenges.

Spinerella smiles sweetly. "That's a silly thing to bet on dearest. Ill hang up twice as many as you." As the three women find new ways to add sparkly bits of confetti that Adora could never hope to vacuum out, the doorbell rings.

Adora is the first one to the door this time. When she opens, she sees Perfuma and Scorpia. "Hey! Come on in."

Scorpia immediately pulls her in for a massive hug, which has Adora release a surprised grunt. She pats the giant woman's back, taken aback by the exuberant affection. From the corner of her eye, she

can see Pefuma giggling sweetly at the interaction. Although Adora hasn't known Scorpia for very long, she really likes her.

"Happy birthday Adora. We brought some snacks and board games." Perfuma smiles gently at her.

"Happy Birthday Adora!" Scorpia holds out a gift enthusiastically, making Adora laugh. The two women started dating last month, but it already feels like the two belong together~~ev~~en if she overlooked their matching soul marks. "I thought you might like this!"

The present is carefully wrapped in non-shiny paper with cute little cactuses on it. Adora would bet her life it's recyclable, both the paper and whatever is inside too.

She dutifully takes the box, noticing that it's kind of heavy. "Aww thanks, Scorp! No worries, I'm sure I'll love it. I'm gonna put it with the other gifts." She holds it for a moment leaning it against her hip. "So, how've you lovebirds been?"

Adora looks at the fledgling couple taking in their blushing faces and tender smiles as they look at each other. They make an interesting pair, Perfuma's wispy frame compared to Scorpia's bulk. "I'm very privileged to get to know Scorpia this way." Perfuma directs her words to Adora, but her eyes are elsewhere.

"Yeah, I don't know if it's a soulmate thing or just us, but I've never been this happy when I've dated someone." One of the first things Adora's noticed about Scorpia when they met is how exceptionally open she is.

"I'm glad to hear it. Could I get you all something to drink or eat?" Adora asks, trying to play the good host. As the question leaves her lips, the doorbell rings again.

Adora shoots the couple an apologetic look which they wave off, shooing her to get the door. She once again answers the door and

now sees Mermista and Seahawk. She looks gorgeous as always, with her dark skin and voluminous hair.

"Hey , you two! Thanks for coming." Adora gives Mermista a hug and shakes Seahawk's hand. He's wearing boots and a vest, which seems like an interesting choice for an indoor dinner party, but then again, Seahawk is always making interesting choices.

"We wouldn't miss it, dearest Adora! You are one of Mermista's closest friends and, if I dare be so bold to say, I consider you a close friend of mine as well." He finishes with a waggle of his eyebrows.

Mermista rolls her eyes at her boyfriend. "Stop being weird Hawk, just say happy birthday like a normal person." Mermista gives Adora a rare warm smile, the type that used to give her butterflies. Now she just feels warm and happy. "Happy Birthday Dora." She says softly , handing over a gift.

This one has goldfish on it which makes her laugh. She looks up at Mermista and knows she's thinking of the same thing ~~the~~ir pet goldfish that died within three days of getting it. They were so shit at keeping it alive, poor thing.

"I brought this!" Seahawk holds out a bottle of rum.

"Looks like we're in for a fun time after dinner then." She looks down at her hands holding the two gifts. "Mind bringing it in for me?"

He nods and Adora steps aside, letting the couple in. The house is teeming with warmth and life now, which is what Adora wanted from her birthday party. She didn't have a soulmate, but she had this ~~h~~er friends who'd been with her through thick and thin.

As she admires the full house, Angel zooms out of the living room and leaps straight into Adora's arms. She feels a split second of panic but manages to catch him, although not without effort. He's only four but he's tall for his age, so when he leaps like that, limbs are flying everywhere.

"Dora! Birthday!" He yells excitedly , dutifully informing her that she was in fact born today.

"Yeah Angel, it's my birthday today." She agrees dotingly . "Now , what're you doing here? I thought you were supposed to be with your dad." Adora gives him a knowing look which he expertly avoids.

A ragged Bow is not far behind. "Sorry , he's getting really fast." Bow rests his hands on his knees panting. Angel cheers, clearly having won whatever game he was playing with his dad.

She leans him on her hip, having to shift his weight to a more comfortable position. "Relax, I got him, you can head to the kitchen."

"No babysitting on your birthday!" Bow admonishes, going to grab his kid. The only problem is Angel's like a little octopus wrapping his legs and arms tightly around Adora.

"It's not babysitting, we're hanging out, right?" Angel nods enthusiastically and Bow sighs in defeat, rolling his eyes. "I'll start up the board games and Angel will be on my team." Adora bops his head, but Angel pays no attention.

"Yes Dora! I like games!" Angel drops down and runs, quickly pulling the other adults towards the games.

They set up a round of charades, everyone wholeheartedly participating except for Bow who was putting the finishing touches on dinner. It all goes well until Seahawk is tucking and rolling around the living room floor, and no one has any idea what the man is trying to say.

"Roly-poly!" Glimmer tries. Seahawk shakes his head while rolling which is really a neck injury hazard.

"Circle!" Angel yells.

"Gymnast"? Netossa asks desperately . The timer beeps and all of Seahawk's team groans.

"T ime's up," Perfuma notes primly . She's been a dictator with that timer, making sure no one tries to take advantage. It was usually Netossa or Glimmer who tried to push their luck.

"What was it?" Angel demands, running straight up to the man in question.

"It was a washing machine!" Seahawk declares proudly .

"How is that a washing machine?" Netossa says, aghast. "Mermista, come get your man!" She shoves Seahawk towards the other team.

"Um no, Im not playing charades with Seahawk in my team. Y ou're just bad at picking teammates if you let him on." Mermista rolls her eyes. It had been a twenty-minute debacle trying to sort the teams which is ridiculous given how the only one who should be this invested in a party game is maybe Angel.

"Dinner 's ready!" Bow calls cheerfully , breaking off the debate.

The group disperses, everyone hustling to the kitchen to grab a plate and serve themselves. Adora has invested in a long dining room table for this exact reason. Most of her friends can sit around the table with a few pulling up fold-out chairs.

The meat is tender and the risotto creamy and rich. "Bow you outdid yourself again, how does this always come out so good?" Adora is practically moaning around a piece of pork. She's definitely going to have seconds.

Bow grins widely. "It' s the same Archer recipe it's always been." He says humbly. Adora isnt surprised, Lance and George can *cook.*

When Adora finishes eating she leans back and closes her eyes, comfortably full, she feels someone tug on her hand and she opens

one eye. Angel is staring at her, with wide eyes. Adora moves her chair, so he has room to clamor onto her lap.

"Birthday cake!" Adora groans when she notices everyone is crowded around her with smiles.

"No guys I said it was okay!" Having a group of people sing happy birthday is such an awkward experience. Adora hates being the center of attention.

"Too bad suck it up," Netossa tells her evenly.

They all sing that terrible song, kind of off-key but with no lack of enthusiasm. She looks at the big '30' candle on the cake and feels a twinge of something in her gut but she ignores it, instead encouraging Angel to blow out the candles. She's warm and loved, surrounded by all of her friends, her nephew in her lap, and a slice of cake in her hand. She might chalk it up as her best birthday ever.

As the evening winds down, Adora's nerves wind up. She goes outside for a bit to clear her head. It's kind of cold but that's exactly what she's looking for, a bite to drown out her thoughts.

She's alone for a few moments until a figure stands next to her, leaning against the porch railing. "Do you think youll miss it?" Mermista asks. Her voice is even and dry but Adora knows her well enough to pick out the concern there.

When Adora breathes out she can see fog in the chill winter air. "Miss what?" Adora plays dumb, thinking Mermista will drop it.

She looks at her incredulously. "Your soul mark."

Adora's eyes snap to hers. They hadn't talked about soulmates since their breakup. She sighs. "I guess. I don't know. It's weird. Growing up, everyone was always said how lucky I was that my soul mark was on my shoulder, how much easier it would be for me to find my

soulmate."Adora snorts thinking of her weird geometric heart splayed widely on her shoulder. "That didn't work out really ."

Mermista reaches up to Adora's left shoulder and touches the fabric hiding her soul mark from the world. At least for the rest of the night. "Maybe if we hadn't spent so much time together you would have found them by now."Mermista drops her arm and takes a step back from Adora.

Adora reaches out and grabs her hand and catches her eyes. "Hey , if I don't regret the time, we spent together then you shouldn't either . At least not on my behalf."

Mermista pulls her hand out of Adora's but keeps her eyes on the blonde. Adora shrugs, focusing on the cold seeping into her skin. "I didn't think seeing my soulmate would feel like it did."Mermista offers as a defense and explanation.

Adora holds her hand up. They talked about what happened they don't need to get into again, tonight of all nights. "Merms, you don't have to feel guilty for doing what makes you happy. I understand." Her backyard was incredibly dark now, the backlight providing minimal lighting.

"Y ou know, I always said I didn't give a rat's ass about meeting my soulmate but you never said anything. How do you feel about it all"? Mermista asks, genuinely curious.

She looks at her exand thinks for a moment. How to explain that she'd believed in soulmates since she was little but that after Mara died, that belief died with her. Some part of Adora, whatever is left of who she was before she finished high school wants deeply, but the rest of her is afraid, terrified of finding that person.

It's too raw and too real to talk about. Especially with Mermista, the woman who left her for her own soulmate. "I'm not sure that I want to talk about it Merms. It feels weird."In truth, she has never

told anyone how much the idea of finding her soulmate terrifies her. She wasn't about to start with her ex

"Okay , that's fair but you're gonna be okay? Do you want me to get you someone else?" She asks brown eyes staring at her patiently .

"Don't worry about me. I'll be fine. I always am." Mermista gives her a sad nod of understanding.

"Take care of yourself, Adora. I'm going to grab Seahawk and go home." Adora gives her a grateful nod. She stays outside for a bit longer until the tips of her fingers feel numb.

When she walks back in, Angel's asleep on the couch and the adults left are playing some new board game Scorpia and Perfuma brought. Adora looks up at the clock. It's eleven at night.

"Hey thank you so much for coming, it' s made my birthday incredibly special to share it with you. But I need to do this last part on my own alright?" Adora looks down at the ground as she says it. She isn't ashamed exactly but it's the closest description.

Her friends all look at her with varying degrees of sadness. Within twenty minutes everything is packed up and everyone is saying goodbye.

"Don't you dare touch a dish in that kitchen, I'm going to come by early tomorrow to clean. No cleaning on your birthday!" Glimmer warns Adora, tears in her eyes. Adora nods.

Everyone else says a quick goodbye. Bow carefully picks up Angel from the couch. Adora places a light kiss on his forehead and squeezes Bow's shoulder . He smiles reassuringly at her.

Her house feels so big when she clicks the front door lock in place. She knows Glimmer might yell at her later, but she ends up doing the dishes just to have something to do.

She tries not to think about whats going to happen, just thinking about getting all the suds off of each individual plate. She almost drops a plate when a piercing cold feeling catches her off guard. She looks up at the clock again. Its midnight.

She cleans off her hands and walks to her bathroom, anxiety and worry creeping into her. She feels a little queasy as she looks for the mirror. She cant help the tears that well up as she lifts her shirt sleeve.

Her soul mark, the dark ink she was born with, disappeared. Her shoulder is all unblemished skin as if nothing had been there before. As if no one was ever meant for Adora and there wouldnt be such a person again.

Her soul mark is gone and Adora has never felt more alone in her life.

Chapter End Notes

> This chapter is mostly some setup but next chapter we get to introduce Catra and Im so excited!
>
> Please leave comments and kudos as they are my only source of protein. Also, follow me on Twitter for updates and sneak peeks!
>
> Of my multichapter WIPs, Soul Mark AU is the one that is most complete so I would suspect itll get the most regular updates from the lot, although you never know when my brainrot will call me to do something else lol. It should be in the 8 to 10 chapter range depending on a few things.
>
> Speaking of things that have derailed my multichapter WIP plans, check out these two long one-shots if youd like!
>
> Temps Volé: This is for if you ever wondered about what Nonbinary Lumberjack Adora and French Accent Artist Catra

would be like if they had a whole Bonnie and Clyde past. I promise it is both more and less confusing than this.

Hidden Treasure: This is a bunch of pirate tropes stacked on each other to make the most pirate-y Catra and princess-y Adora fall in love.

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

Adora meets a bartender.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora lays in her bed, her shoulder positively throbbing. It feels like the skin should be burnt to a crisp from how painful and sensitive it feels there. But when she runs her fingers gently over where her mark used to be it's all smooth and unblemished~~as~~ if nothing had ever been there. She hasnt been able to wear sleeves all week or even lay down on her left side from the pain.

In the months before she turned thirty, Adora did a fair bit of research on the experience of losing a soul mark. It isnt something she felt comfortable asking about, usually because the few people she knew who lost their soul marks werent close to her and it was rude to just ask. If it were just the physical pain, she could endure but it' s more than that. Adora feels the absence of her soul mark in a way that defies all her expectations.

Not only was there physical pain to contend with, there were also the social repercussions of losing her mark. Every time anyone even mentions soul marks around her, Glimmer and Bow eye her with concern. It feels like everyone is walking on eggshells, waiting for Adora to crack wide open. There's no way she can go to her friends with these feelings.

She sinks in further into the bed letting herself wallow. She shoves her head under her pillow hoping blocking out the light would somehow help.

But nothing really helps. The worst part by far was the hole in her chest. Some part of her just feels hollow . She's not sure why she honestly never wants to meet her soulmate. Even the thought of meeting them makes her spine tingle with fear. So why did she feel like crying when she thinks of her missing mark?

She knows some people go through soul mark withdrawal, but Adora felt so unattached to hers for so long that she thought she wouldn't have that problem. She thought wrong.

She thinks about taking a bath or maybe reaching out to one of her friends to hang out, but she doesn't really want to do that. She sighs and gets out of bed putting on some clothes and shucking on her shoes. She needs to get out of the house and go somewhere that isn't the place where she lost her mark in the first place.

"C'mon Adora stop it. It' s not like anyone died." She mutters to herself as she finishes tying her shoes.

She starts up her car and ends up just going with no destination in mind. Driving around the neighborhood feels soothing. There are folks she knows walking the street but they pay her no mind, trying to get to their homes before the last of the sunlight dims out. They have families waiting for them inside.

She runs her hands over the steering wheel, enjoying the feel of the leather in her grip. Before she knows it, it's dark out and she has to turn her headlights on. Once she drives out far enough, she turns back but she still doesn't want to go back home. As she's circling back, she decides to take a turn she usually doesn't and notices a few restaurants. She parks her car and looks around and decides to get out and walk around.

She ends up going to a bar she never visited before. The Crimson Waste is a hole in the wall, a dive bar really. On the one hand, she's surprised she'd never seen it before given how close it is to her house, but its nondescript appearance makes her think it's a bar that

doesn't want to be found. She doesn't really want to be found either, so she gets it.

She hesitates at the front entrance, wondering if she's really about to go to a random bar alone on a Wednesday night. She sighs and opens the door letting the warmth of the indoor heating seep into her bones. She *really* doesn't want to go home yet.

The whole place looks old but clean. There's a long bar top with stools and then a few tables with chairs along the edges of the wall. In the back corner, there's a small stage with what looks like a karaoke bar set up. It's a Wednesday night so there are only two or three people sitting at one of the tables when she walks in.

Adora briefly considers sitting at a table but feels awkward taking up so much space. Especially because she's alone. She shakes her head as the last word reverberates in her mind.

She makes her way to the bar to sit on a stool instead. Adora puts her hand on the wood, it feels grainy and chipped in some spots, but it's clearly well loved. She notices some laminated menus sitting atop the bar. She eyes the menu with interest. It looks like the bar not only has a varied selection of beers but also a full-service kitchen. Adora's stomach grumbles at the thought. She'd driven straight through dinner and the throbbing in her shoulder had left her without an appetite. It hurt less now weirdly, maybe she just needed something else to focus on.

"What can I get you?" The voice is a warm rasp that Adora feels to her toes. She looks up from the menu, planning on asking for whatever beer is good on tap but is silenced by how absolutely *gorgeous* the bartender is.

She's a tiny slip of a woman, she probably wouldn't reach Adora's chin if she stood close. She holds herself in a way that just projects confidence, one hand on her hip like she can't bother to take Adora's order, even though she'd just asked for it. Her hair looks as if it has a life of its own, a curly mane that belongs on a magazine cover. Her

arms are toned and Adora wishes that she could get a look at her without the bar top in between them.

But what has Adora at a standstill are her eyes. They flash to one side, lively, a well of emotion hidden beneath them. Adora can't tell in the lighting, but it looks like her eyes might be different colors. Adora would love to get a closer look.

She's never seen someone so vibrant and confident. Adora can't help but glance at the woman's exposed left shoulder. She's disappointed when she doesn't see her soul mark reflected back at her. *Ridiculous.* She shakes off the thought, not even sure why it crossed her mind.

The bartender raises an eyebrow at her swinging her weight onto her other leg. "You know, it's common practice to tell service workers your orders verbally, not via telepathy." She states flatly.

"Oh, I'm sorry uh—" Adora sputters trying to regain her balance.

She leans forward and Adora catches a whiff of her perfume. "Cat got your tongue?" The bartender teases, her eyes sparkling like she said a really funny joke. Adora feels like she's missing something, but she can't help but smile at her.

Adora takes a deep breath and looks down at the menu, anything to avoid those piercing eyes that scatter her thoughts into the wind. "Can I get whatever beer you like and—" Adora's eyes desperately rove the menu for any food items that stick out "—could I get the mac and cheese, a burger, and fries?"

The bartender gives her an easy smile that makes her knees feel like jelly. "Sure thing. I'm obligated to warn you that the mac and cheese will absolutely change your life and you'll be forced to come here regularly to feed your addiction." She leans forward and her voice drops lower. "Are you sure you still want it?" Her eyes sparkle as she stares Adora down.

Adora is sure she will be coming around anyways. "Yeah, Im sure." She swallows thickly. "I want." She wants a number of things, her mind is in a whirlwind.

The bartender takes a step back and goes to the taps, eyeing them as if in deep thought. She shoots a glance at Adora and fills up a pint. "Alright. No of fense blondie, but you dont look like an IPA girl, so try this." The bartender sits down a pale gold beer in front of Adora.

Adora takes a tentative sip. It's incredibly light and refreshing, almost sweet. "Oh man, this *is* good." She praises taking another swig of her drink.

The bartender smirks, leaning forward so her face is close to Adora's. Adora's palms begin to sweat. "I figured I had you pegged blondie." The bartender's voice is deep and scratchy, it reminds her of leather and whiskey. She chokes on her beer at the way she says *pegged*.

Adora isnt sure she can function and one look at the smirk playing on the edge of the bartender's mouth tells Adora she knows it too. Adora looks down, hoping her blush isnt noticeable in the lighting.

"What is it? The beer I mean." Adora manages to get out, putting her elbow on the bar top. She notices the bartender staring at her arm so she experimentally flexes. The bartender seems a bit dazed.

Adora grins at the effect she has on the brunette. "You know, I dont think good customer service involves telepathy either." Adora quips, pleased to have the upper hand for the first time in this exchange.

The bartender's eyes snap to Adora's, a faint blush on her cheeks. "Just got lost in thought." She counters. Before Adora could tease her about what kinds of thoughts might be running through her head as she stared at Adora's arms, she continues to speak. "It's a local hefeweizen, has notes of honey and oranges. You cant really get it

at the grocery store if that's what you're thinking."She says knowingly.

Until that moment, Adora had been thinking of grabbing a pack the next time she went grocery shopping. She doesn't say that though. "Why would I want to get it at the store when I can have it with much more pleasant company here"?

Adora knows she is laying it on a bit thick, but this woman started it. If this woman wants to give Adora attention, she is going to revel in it. She narrows her eyes on Adora, and Adora sits on the edge of her seat waiting for what she has to say. But before the bartender could respond, a sharp bell rang out. The brunette looked towards the kitchen window and Adora notices steaming plates of food there.

"That'll be your order , blondie."The bartender walks away and Adora averts her eyes, refusing to get caught staring. It takes all of her willpower to just keep her eyes down, to not look up and drink her in. When Adora hears her footsteps, she glances back up in time to see the bartender deposit a steaming plate of food in front of Adora.

She stares Adora down for a brief moment before smiling. "I'm going to check on my other customers, you think you'll be okay"?The bartender's tone is teasing. Adora desperately wants to know her name.

"I think I'll survive."Adora shoots back a smile, this time taking a chance and watching the woman walk around the bar to attend to the patrons at the tables. She makes sure to not turn around in her stool though, that would be too much.

With no one to talk to, she starts tucking into her mac and cheese, At the first mouthful, she has to bite her lip to strangle down a moan. It's so cheesy and hot, but there are other seasonings that complement the pasta perfectly. *What the hell did they put in this?*

The fries are not too thin but still crunchy and the burger tastes like bar food should. She has trouble deciding what she should eat first,

so she ends up taking a couple of bites and switching, quickly making a dent in the heaping pile of food.

"So what do you think?"The bartender pops back over the bar as she eyes Adora's half-finished food. "It looks like it went over well." She says with an amused twinge to her voice.

"I might sell my firstborn for this mac and cheese recipe,"Adora says seriously, hoping she finds it funny.

The bartender's shoulders shake as she lets out a full-bellied laugh. She doesnt think she' s ever heard anyone except maybe children laugh with such sheer joy . "I told you!It's incredible. It was the only thing I ate for every shift I had for like my whole first week working here."The bartender explains, her eyes excited. Her expression is open and honest in a way it wasn't earlier in the night.

Adora cant hold back her grin as she talks to her . "I dont blame you. If I had access to this regularly, Id probably have to live at the gym to compensate."Adora pats her stomach, full and satisfied.

"I'm sure you'd be just fine."The bartender makes a show of giving Adora a once over. If Adora subtly tenses her muscles that's her business. Her fake perusal becomes a little more serious as she looks Adora in the eyes. "So, why are you sitting alone at a bar on a Wednesday night?"The bartender asks casually but her eyes betray a genuine interest in the answer.

Adora has to think because she genuinely forgot what brought her out of her house. Her shoulder throbs, almost as if trying to remind her. She hasn't spent a single moment thinking about her soul mark or soulmates since she laid eyes on this woman.

"I'm not sitting alone, Im here with you."Adora counters. She means for it to be a joke or a deflection, but it feels true.

"Y ou know what I mean."The bartender narrows her eyes but there' s something flustered about her expression. Adora cant tell from the

lighting, but it looks like the bartender might be blushing again.

Adora rubs her hand across her face, a sigh escaping her lips. "Just been a few weird days, I guess. Something happened in my life recently and my friends pity me. I don't want to deal with it."Adora clasps her hands together, feeling a different type of nerves than before.

She eyes her for a moment. "Do you think you're pity worthy?"The words sound almost like a teasing coo but there is a genuine question hidden within them.

This bartender would probably think Adora would be worth pitying if she knew Adora lost her soul mark. Most people pity those who lose their soul mark even more so than those who can't make things work with their soulmate.

She thinks about bringing up that her soul mark is gone but she feels queasy about it. She couldn't imagine getting sympathy from this woman or hearing her talk about her own soulmate. It would be crushing at this point.

Adora bites her lip, deciding that even if she is pitiful, she doesn't want to be. At least not in her eyes. "No. I'm not worth pitying."She finally settles on. "What happened isn't great but I don't want it to define me. I don't want to be treated like a kicked puppy."

The bartender smiles wide. "Great answer, because there was no way I was going to join your pity party crew."Adora laughs loud and clear. She can't remember the last time she had this much fun with someone new.

"Do you need another beer?"The bartender says as she picks up Adora's plates.

Adora shakes her head, and the bartender busses the plates. She gives the bartender her credit card to close out her account. She watches as the bartender presses the necessary buttons with

practiced ease. When she gives back her card, Adora leaves a good tip.

She knows that soon she’s going to leave, and she doesn't know when she'll see this woman again. She takes a moment to take a deep breath. "What's your name?" Adora tries, thinking that maybe they could be friends.

"I don't tell strangers my name, hot stuff." The bartender shoots off, almost like a knee-jerk reaction.

Adora is undeterred. "If you tell me your name, we wouldn't be strangers anymore!" Adora smiles winningly. "Besides, I thought you were in my non-pity party crew?" She needles leaning closer to her but still a respectable distance away.

"I think I said I *wouldn't* be in your pity party crew. Don't recall joining any other ones." She leans forward and Adora's suspicion that her eyes are two different colors is confirmed. Stars, her eyes are beautiful. Blue and Hazel.

"Well, it's currently a party of one. Just you." Adora gives her a pout and the bartender laughs, lightly shoving Adora’s shoulder as she turns and grabs a rag to wipe down the bar top.

"Okay fine, fine. You win this time blondie. It’s Catra." *Catra.* She smiles softly and Adora imagines this is what floating feels like. She watches as she makes quick work of the bar top before cleaning off her hands on another cleaner towel.

"Cool. Awesome." Adora clears her throat, suddenly nervous. "My name is Adora." She reaches her hand out over the bar top for a handshake. Catra looks Adora in the eyes and instead of shaking her hand, she grabs it and brings it up to her face, placing a soft kiss on her knuckles.

Adora tries to keep it together, but she knows she is failing from the smirk Catra sends her way. Adora mumbles her goodbyes and starts

to walk away, her brain on autopilot. She can feel the grin on her face, and she knows she probably looks like a fool, but she can't bring herself to care.

"Hey! I'll see you around?" Catra calls from behind the bar. Adora turns to look at her. Catra's brow is furrowed in concern, and Adora realizes she might think that she made Adora uncomfortable. Which she has, in the best way possible.

"Yeah. I'll be back. You'll probably be sick of seeing me." Adora promises. She beams at Catra, letting her see that she was anything but bothered by her gesture. Catra's shoulders relax, a small smile overtaking her face.

"Alright then. Take care blondie." Catra gives her a small wave and Adora thinks her heart might beat out of her chest. "I work every Wednesday." She adds with a raised brow. Adora nods, letting Catra know she heard her, then walks out to the parking lot.

Her back hits the cold air outside and she already wishes she never left the bar.

Chapter End Notes

I'm so soft for these two here. That's it, that's the a/n.

Kudos and comments are appreciated! Also follow me on Twitter

Yesterday I posted first date fluff for the SPOP Creative Flex challenge check it out if you'd like: Double Blind Date.

Next time on Burnt in My Skin: Adora visits home and our girls get closer.

Next week: chapter two of Battle Cry

Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

Adora asks Catra out on a date.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora isn't exactly at her most comfortable laying down on the ground while Glimmer lays on the couch. She can't really move from the ground though, because Angel is sprawled on top of her, eyes intent on the screen. Every time she so much as shifts her weight he turns around and glares, a look that makes him look uncannily like his mother.

She sighs, looking up at Glimmer who gives her an unimpressed look in return. "I told you that letting him use you as a pillow was a terrible idea." She shakes her head.

"He's only going to want to do things like this for a little while longer. And he has those big sad eyes like Bow." She defends herself. Adora can hardly say no to Angel when it matters, she doesn't bother with saying no for things like this, where she's more than happy to comply.

"So, anything new? Now that you're Angel's hostage and I can ask you whatever I want." Glimmer adds gleefully from atop the couch. She can hear Bow messing around in the kitchen, but he just went in so she doesn't expect him anytime soon.

Adora rolls her eyes, throwing her head back on the pillow she set up in her attempt to get comfortable. "I should've known that Angel is just a trap." She sighs, trying not to twitch enough to bother the toddler. "I'm really good Glim. A lot better than I was when it first happened." She offers, getting right to what she knows Glimmer

wants to talk about. They'd hung out but had been avoiding discussing her soul mark.

Her shoulder didn't hurt anymore, only sometimes if she was out in the sun for too long or if she was feeling a particularly strong emotion. "I don't feel as sad anymore." She's been seeing Catra at the bar and that honestly has changed everything for Adora.

Glimmer quiets at that and her face grows serious. "How sad were you feeling, Adora?"

Adora sighs and looks down at Angel, making sure he is still tuned into the TV. "It was bad." She admits readily. "I've never felt that way before." She doesn't have words for how cold and painful the loneliness felt in those days after her mark left her.

Glimmer reaches down and runs her hands through Adora's hair the same way she does for Angel when he's upset. "I'm sorry I—" She bites her lip. "Did you not think you could come to us?" Her words aren't judgmental, just sad.

"I did but Glimmer, you haven't been the most accepting and understanding about this." Adora's frustration seeps in her voice. "And I know you love me, and you'd be there to help but I—I didn't have space for anything more." If Glimmer and Bow had made her feel even a little self-conscious about losing her soul mark, she doesn't know what she would have done.

Glimmer sighs. "I'm sorry. I know Bow and I will never get it and even though I do think I was right to try to get you to find your soulmate, I shouldn't have pushed as hard as I did."

Adora nods, it's enough. "I'm glad you see that now at least."

She feels movement across her torso and sees Angel move off her lap to get closer to the screen, still absorbed as he crawls across the floor. She doesn't know how he can focus this hard.

Glimmer moves to sit beside Adora now. "Soul mark or no, we're always here for you. You don't have to come to us, but we *are* here."

Adora nods her head. "I know."

"Okay, as long as you know." She picks some lint out of the rug they are both sitting on. "Anything else that's new?" She asks with a smile, trying to lighten the mood, Adora suspects.

She immediately thinks of a pair of brilliant eyes: one blue, the other like honey. Adora's smile grows bigger. "No, but you know, I think life is going to really turn for the better for me." She says confidently.

Glimmer gives her a surprised look that melts into a soft smile. "I hope it does. You deserve to be happy."

Adora thinks about Catra again. "I'm starting to think so too."

She loves her little Subaru but for longer drives, it really takes a toll to sit in the smaller car. Adora's knees hurt from the drive between Bright Moon and Eternia. She doesn't do it as often as she should, and she can't say it's because of the leg pain. She shakes out one of her legs as she knocks on the dark wooden door.

Hope opens the door with a look that Adora knows to be happiness, but likely wouldn't be obvious to anyone else. Adora gives her a brief hug and moves inside. "Hey mom, how's everything?" She asks.
Adora takes the opportunity to look around the living room, letting out a quiet sigh. All the furniture is the same, a mix-matched collection of garage sale furniture, the antique kind that usually costs a bundle if you try to buy them from a carpenter. Hope hasn't changed anything at all since Adora graduated high school. She suspects it's because it all reminds her of Mara, but she doesn't really want to ask.

"You know, the same." Hope gets a far-off look in her eye. It's always a mixed bag when Adora visits Hope. Adora loves her deeply, but it

feels like Mara's ghost hangs around when they are together , standing between them.

"Have you hung out with Raz at least?" Adora tries with a raised eyebrow.

That brings the edges of a smile to Hope's face. Raz lives next door and always brings Hope pie. "Yes, Raz brought a blueberry pie when I told her you would be visiting today. She mentioned she might pass by, but her memory isn't what it used to be." Hope nods, looking thoughtful. "It's strange to think that it took me so long to appreciate Raz for who she is. I hope Mara can see us getting along now." Raz and Mara had been best of friends from the moment they all moved in next door . It took Mara passing for Hope to warm up to the eclectic woman.

Hope's gray eyes grow unbearably sad, tears welling up. She shakes her head. "Enough about me. How have you felt since your birthday?" Hope's tone is cautious as she looks at Adora. She knows Hope wasn't asking about the festivities.

"Honestly? A little empty ." Adora admits some of the truth. She doesn't want to get into details with her mom but she's lost something bigger than Adora has. She's the closest she can think to someone who understands.

"I would imagine so," Hope says as she rubs her forearm where her soul mark is, a sword of all things. "I can't imagine not having mine," Hope confesses, looking down at her arm longingly. "Have you thought more about searching for this soulmate of yours?" She asks curiously.

Adora shakes her head. "I don't think I want to try . I feel like if I try now it'll be a dead end anyways." Adora hesitates. She reaches out and grabs Hope's hand. "I mean maybe there' s a reason why I haven't found them. How many years did I wear short-sleeved clothes hoping that someone would see?" Adora lived in bro tanks and ripped sleeveless t-shirts all throughout high school. "And then

when you know..."Adora's eyes flicker to Hope, hesitating on the words that she thinks but usually doesn't say aloud.

"When Mara left, it felt like a part of me was gone too," Hope confirms. They've discussed this before.

Adora clears her throat. "Yeah. Having a soulmate didn't feel like this romantic thing anymore. It's been so hard for you." Adora squeezes Hope's fingers. "But I've been getting out more. I've made a new ... friend."

Adora has returned to the bar three times already, spending all of her Wednesday nights talking and flirting with Catra. She'd never admit this to anyone but she moved her travel days so she can be back by next Wednesday.

"A friend?" Hope's voice is even but amusement lurked behind it as she eyes Adora with a smirk.

"Yeah, I mean, I hope she's my friend," Adora mutters under her breath. It feels like friendship, but they haven't exchanged numbers or seen each other outside the Crimson Waste.

"Why do you say that? Can you not tell?" Genuine confusion pinches Hope's voice.

"We have only hung out where she works. She is a bartender and I've gone by the bar a few times." She isn't ready to admit to Hope that hanging out with Catra at the Crimson Waste is beginning to feel like the highlight of her week.

Hope reaches out, turning Adora's head. "She brings light to you, Adora. I can see it on your face."

Adora sputters. "Mom! It isn't like that really. We're just friends." Adora repeats it to herself every time she heads to the bar to see Catra.

"But you'd like for it to be more?" Hope presses.

"Yeah," Adora admits in a quiet whisper.

"Seeing her is like getting to see the stars dance up close." Adora feels horrified that the sentence comes out of her mouth about a person who might not even consider her a friend, but it is true. Catra is magic.

Hope gives her a knowing look. "Even with the knowledge I have now, I wouldn't trade a single moment of what I had with your mother. Even if I knew I'd be without her this long, it has been worth every moment I did have her." Hope levels her a long look. "Soul mark or no soul mark. This woman seems important to you, Adora. Follow that."

Adora looks away from Hope's intense stare. "I'll think about it." She allows. She pulls her hand from Hope's. "Now, where did you leave Razz blueberry pie? It's a three-hour drive and I'm starving!" Adora makes her way to the kitchen, wanting to make the most of her visit with her mom.

She's almost panting by the time she makes it into the bar, having walked as fast as humanly possible from the car to the front entrance. The moment she opens the door she hears her name. "Hey Dr! I was wondering when you'd make it out here." Catra was cleaning the bartop with a rag.

She can't help the smile that makes its home on her face as she walks towards the brunette. "Aww, did you miss me, Cat?" Adora teases.

She waves Adora off. "No way! I just wanted to make sure you weren't dying or anything." Catra is definitely blushing, and it makes Adora's heart race even more than the brisk walk.

She rolls her eyes. "W ell, not dead yet. I got held up babysitting my friend's kid."

Adora broke multiple traffic laws to get to the bar only half an hour after she usually shows up. She would have to give Glimmer an explanation later as to why she sprinted into her car while yelling goodbye over her shoulder.

"Y ou have any of those?" Catra looks uncertain as she asks the question and Adora has no idea what she is on about.

"Any of what?" Adora asks for clarification as she sits down, leaning forward on the bar.

"Kids." Catra levels Adora with an even stare.

Adora snorts. "Ha, no. Usually , you want to have somebody to raise kids with." The words slip up and Adora hopes that Catra will let that slide. "I mean not that there' s anything wrong with having them on your own or anything." She backtracks quickly .

"Y ou don't have your soulmate waiting for you back home?" Catra's tone is needling, almost mocking as she flashes Adora a dangerous smile. They'd talked about so many things, but they seemed to mutually agree to not discuss soulmates. Adora isn't sure if it' s a good or bad thing that Catra is broaching the topic so openly.

She shakes her head slowly. "No, I haven't met them. Whoever they are."

Catra is still eyeing her expectantly . Adora stares back, wondering where Catra is going with this. Catra then rolls her eyes, looking down at the bar between them. "Then you must be waiting on your soulmate like half the world." Catra's words take a bitter turn. Adora feels her eyebrows jump in surprise.

"Nope." Adora pops the p. Catra looks at her curiously but still guarded. Adora decides to take a risk. "I turned 30 in January , so I

dont have my soul mark anymore. That is actually what all the pity parties were about when I first showed up. How I ended up at the bar."

"Not the sparkling company?" Catra bats her eyelashes, although her teasing misses its mark because her voice is breathless.

"The company helps," Adora says giving Catra a shy grin. "Apparently , not having my soul mark means that I have a three percent chance of finding my soulmate." The internet has statistics on these things apparently. Glimmer was kind enough to point them out in the last year when she was trying to get Adora to try searching for her soulmate. "With those odds, Im not holding my breath on them showing up." Adora finishes. "Are you with your soulmate? Or are you waiting around for them like half the world?" Adora uses air quotes to emphasize Catra's words.

Adora can feel her palms sweat, thinking of how she will feel if Catra says she has found her other half. Catra shrugs, a picture of carelessness. "Nah. I havent thought about my soul mark since it disappeared off me." The blasé way she says it makes Adora feel like that wasnt the whole truth.

Adora doesnt press for more. "It aches sometimes. Feels empty , without the soul mark." Adora admits in a quiet whisper staring down at the bar top. Catra absentmindedly rubs her left shoulder.

Adora looks up at Catra. Both of Catra's hands press down on the bar top. Adora takes a chance and slowly slides her hand next to Catra's, only their pinkies touching. The small touch feels like it vibrates through Adora's body .

"But I dont ache when Im here with you." Adora shrugs apologetically like she knows she shouldnt say something so forward to a woman who is just trying to do her job.

Catra looks like she stops breathing, disbelief coloring her face. Adora gives her a smile. "Do you think I should try the nachos this

time? I feel like you convince me not to every time."Adora gives Catra the out, instinctively knowing she needs it.

Catra smiles, a knowing look on her face. She delivers the same rant as always about how the nachos are the only bad thing on the Crimson Waste menu and their night continues like every Wednesday since Adora was lucky enough to have met Catra.

She receives a picture of Catra cuddling the cutest cat in the universe. Adora coos at her phone, regardless of how stupid that looks. After Catra gave Adora her phone number they started messaging each other nonstop, she can't believe this is the first she sees of this cat. She is waiting on her friends for an all-girls brunch date but that is going to have to be put on hold for a moment.

She calls Catra immediately, tapping her foot as she waits for her to pick up.

"What's up blondie, why you blowing up my phone?"Adora can hear the smirk in Catra's voice.

"W e have been friends for two months now and you have been holding out on me."Adora accuses, going so far as to lift a finger in the air and tamp her foot down again. "I can't believe you had a cat for this long and I hadn't seen a picture!This is a breach of friendship!"It is a *really* cute cat.

"Oh, I'm sorry Adora how will you ever forgive me for having a pet"? Catra's tone is all petulance.

Adora answers it seriously. "I need like, at least ten more pictures to start. What's their name?"Adora asks in a coo.

Catra chuckles. "That's my baby Melog. I've had them for I think three years now?They're the most important thing I brought with me when I moved to Bright Moon."Adora hears a meow over the phone and coos again. Catra cackles.

"You should bring them to the bar." Adora decides she really wants to meet them but she doesn't want to invite herself to Catra's place, so it's the only solution.

Catra scoffs. "Yeah, that'll go over great with Huntara. And the food inspectors too."

Adora lets her mouth get away from her. "Can I call you tonight?" It's Friday and the fact that Adora has to wait until Wednesday to see Catra is driving her crazy already.

Catra lets out another laugh. "Sure thing, blondie. I'll call you once I'm in my jammies."

Adora blushes, remembering the salacious look in Catra's eyes when she casually mentioned that she sleeps naked. Adora sees Mermista and Perfuma approaching her, sending questioning glances to her phone.

Adora ignores them. "I'm looking forward to it. I'll try not to bug you too much from now till then."

Catra lets out an incredulous hum. "You could never bother me, Adora." Catra's voice sounds sweet and warm when she says it.

Adora knows the grin on her face must look stupid. "Good to know. Take care of yourself yeah?" Adora really doesn't want to get off the phone, but she hopes it doesn't show in her voice.

"Will do, blondie. I'll try not to injure myself while I cuddle Melog. Bye."

Adora rolls her eyes fondly as she hangs up.

Perfuma eyes Adora knowingly, a small smirk growing on her face. "Your aura looks so clear Adora. I've never seen it like this." She keeps just staring and Adora can feel her cheeks turning red.

"Perfuma. I love you, but I have no idea what that means." Adora never gets Perfuma's woo shit, but she has a feeling she isn't going to like whatever she's trying to tell her.

"It means you look like you got laid, Dora," Mermista says as she eyes the blonde. Her voice sounds bored but her eyes flash in amusement.

Adora rubs her neck and swings her weight from side to side. "Haha, definitely not. Im ready to eat if you two are?" She tries. Adora hopes a change of scenery will put her friends off the line of questioning.

"We are still waiting on Glimmer." Mermista points out and now she's smirking too. Dang.

"Who were you on the phone with?" Perfuma asks outright, her naked curiosity palpable in the air.

"You know, a friend." She says uneasily. Catra is her friend, she just feels *things* that she hasn't fully decided she wants to tell anyone about.

Perfuma and Mermista exchange a loaded look. Adora swallows, looking elsewhere. They seem to take pity on her. "Well whatever it is, seems good for you. You should keep doing it." Mermista says firmly.

It's quiet for a moment before Glimmer's voice sounds out as if by magic. "I'm sorry Im late! Angel didn't want to stay with mom and I had to deal with his crying for like fifteen more minutes. What did I miss?" Glimmer looks frazzled, power-walking straight to the group.

She freezes as she stares at her best friend. She *really* doesn't want to tell Glimmer about Catra. "Nothing important, we were just about to call you," Perfuma explains as she shoots Adora a look. Mermista smirks at the lie Perfuma tells but she nods along, backing her up.

They go to dinner and Adora puts Catra out of her mind until she falls asleep on the phone talking with her that night.

She feels like a teenager again, stretching her legs under the covers as she holds her phone on speaker resting on her torso. She's listening to Catra tell her a story about a terrible patron who returned multiple half-eaten dishes.

"You know I can definitely beat that guy up for you." Adora offers. If she saw someone being half as rude as what Catra is relaying, she probably would have spoken up. She likes to think she would have just told him to stop being an ass, but a part of her recognizes that she might get physical in that situation.

"Relax Rambo, Huntara came out and the dude practically peed himself. Paid his tab and left without saying another word," Catra says and it crackles over the line. "I just wish that I'd thought to bring her out earlier so I wouldn't have dealt with his bullshit for as long as I did."

Adora can hear Catra shifting, a long, drawn-out sigh escaping her lips. She can close her eyes and almost imagine what Catra looks like, probably stretching in her bed, her cat not far away. Adora bites her own and tries to banish the thought and any other that might try to follow it.

"What about you Dr. How was your day?" There's just something about the way she asks, the genuineness of it that makes her feel like Catra really wants to know and isn't just saying it to continue the conversation.

"It was good. I went to brunch." She starts off.

Catra hums. "I know that part. Did it go well?"

Adora nods her head instinctively before speaking. "Yeah, it was nice hanging out with my friends. The food was good, and they're all

doing well so I can't really complain." She glosses over the suggestive comments and heavy looks she received from Perfuma and Mermista. "Then I went out on my kayak in the afternoon."

She can almost hear Catra perking up. "You have a kayak?" She asks.

Adora laughs at her excitement. "Yeah, I've always loved kayaking and water generally." It was one of the things that made her a good fit with Mermista. "There's a nearby lake I really like so I want and spent the afternoon." It's one of the things that she keeps private, her spot on the lake. It's the one place she can just be by herself.

"I've never been kayaking before," Catra says casually, and Adora bites her lip to keep the *want* in.

She wants to invite Catra to go out with her on the lake. She wants to ask to video call so she can see Catra, what the light in her eyes as she laughs, maybe notice the way she grows sleepier as the call drags on. She doesn't do that. It would be too much. Besides, if she does ask Catra out, she'd like to do it face-to-face.

Adora sighs, "It's pretty fun. You should go some time." She continues to talk about anything but her feelings with the girl that makes her feel more than anyone else.

It was once again Wednesday and Adora is in her favorite place.

"I just don't see how you can say that super strength is the best power. That's boring! Or." Catra looks deep in thought, then snaps one of her fingers in an 'aha' gesture. "I would want, like, to shoot fire out of my hands or like become a human flame!" Catra looks positively gleeful. "Or have a whip. I'd look real sexy with a whip." Catra eyes Adora, challenging her to say otherwise.

Adora doesn't take the bait. "I thought we were discussing superpowers?" She asks instead.

I could set my whip on fire. Problem solved. Very super. Very powerful." Adora knows the damage is done and the mental image of Catra with a whip would stay with her until at least next week.

She huffs. "Well if I had super strength, I would get so much pizza from helping my friends move!" Adora says triumphantly, totally winning the argument.

Catra gives her a soft look that doesn't match the tone of the conversation so far. She leans forward and curls a wayward strand of hair behind Adora's ear. Adora is pretty sure the whole bar can hear her heartbeat. "How are you so good about helping others and so hungry at the same time?" Catra asks seriously, her eyes alight with amusement.

Catra looks so passionate and lighthearted tonight. They are talking about the most inane things but her eyes are sparkling, the edge of a smile always on her lips. She looks so unbelievably gorgeous when she is this carefree.

"Do you want to go on a date with me?" The words just spill out of Adora like she is mind-controlled by an alien warlord. She's thought them over in her head so many times but now that they are out she can't say she regrets them.

Catra bites her lip and hesitates, eyes flooding with an apology. Adora's heart stops. "It's not that I don't want to I just... I'm not ready for that." Catra groans and puts her head in her hands, as if hiding from the conversation. Adora feels her breath leave her chest. "I like you, Adora. Really." Catra mumbles into her hands. "You deserve someone who can give you want and I don't think that's me right now. I'm kind of dealing with my own shit." Catra admits. "Friends?" She asks tentatively, one eye, the blue one, peeking out to look at Adora. She reminds Adora of Angel when he thinks he is in trouble.

Adora melts a little. "Of course, Cat. Well always be friends first." Catra is staring at her like she has seen a ghost. Adora hesitates. "If it's weird for you, I can give you space?" Adora suggests. She's

kicking herself for coming on too strong, being too into this beautiful woman and scaring her off.

Catra snaps out of it. "No! No, please stay ." She stops as if a thought occurs to her. "I mean, unless *you* want space then that's totally fine." She rushes out.

The idea of not having at least Wednesday nights with Catra makes Adora feel nauseous.

"I want to stay ," Adora says firmly , moving her hand off the bartop, safely away from Catra. Her hands twitch out of sight.

The silence drags for a moment, the heaviness of Catra's answer lingering between them. Catra averts her eyes but after a moment collects herself and slowly shoots Adora a tentative smile. "What I don't get is, if you have super strength, why would you want a sword instead of a hammer?" Catra's question sets of f their discussion again with Adora defending her honor as a sword lesbian.

It isn't until Adora gets back to her house that she lets herself feel the bone-deep sorrow of being rejected by Catra.

Chapter End Notes

> Lots of plot and time moving forward in this one! W e are cruising along and moving! What do y'all think? Did you expect Adora to get rejected? Let me know .
>
> As always if you know you know-kudos and comments, the way to my heart. Also, follow me on Twitter.
>
> Yesterday, I posted Muscle Memory which is a very long fluff and hurt/comfort modern Amnesia AU one-shot. Check it out if you'd like!
>
> Next time: Catra and Adora's worlds collide in an unexpected way.

Next week: Chapter two of Secrets Are the Enemy of Intimacy will hopefully go up!

Chapter 4

Chapter Summary

Catra and Adora end up running into each other by chance.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The beginnings of spring flourished, and with such lovely weather came Glimmer and Bow's famous barbecues. Adora wears her favorite bro tank and shorts for the occasion, ready to man the grill at a moment's notice. She doesn't have much to do beforehand so she heads over early to help set up. She'd asked Catra if she wanted to chat on the phone but she was busy. At the thought of Catra, she can't help but soften. Things were still a little awkward since she got rejected but they'd mostly moved past it.

"You look different. Like *happy* happy." Glimmer notes, eyeing Adora suspiciously. She puts down the folding chairs that she was bringing over from the shed in favor of looking at Glimmer. The moment her arms free up, Angel launches himself at her with a giggle.

"Was I not happy before?" Adora asks as she tosses Angel up in the air.

"Dora happy!" Angel cheered, mostly motivated by having Adora continue to jostle him about.

"Yeah, bud!" She cheers and then looks at the cherub's mother. "Like Angel said, I'm always happy." Adora tickles his sides earning her another giggle. She loves how at ease and free he is. She kind of wonders if she was ever that way.

Glimmer grunts as she puts down the chairs she's been carrying. "No, but Adora you're glowing. You've been glowing for months now."

I kind of want to say your pregnant but unless you've been hiding *a lot* from us, I doubt that's what it is."

Adora snorts, rolling her eyes. "Glim, I promise you that I'm not pregnant via any earthly or heavenly means. Please put that thought out of your brain. It's weird." She's thought about telling Glimmer for weeks now about Catra but every time she thinks about it, something stops her. What would she even say? *I've met the most amazing woman Glim, but without context, it might seem like I'm stalking her at work.* They hang out on Wednesday nights in person and talk on the phone a few times a week. How is she supposed to explain to Glimmer how much that means to her?

Glimmer rolls her eyes back. "Fine." She huffs, shooting her another distrustful look. "But I *will* figure out what has got you so peppy." Glimmer warns, finger up in the air and pointing at Adora.

"Who all is coming today?" Adora interrupts Glimmer's train of thought with the only thing that could distract her at this point. Besides, she also wants to know who is showing up since she hasn't paid much attention to the guest list. Win-win.

"You know, our crowd. Seahawk and Mermista will be here too since Bow has a huge bro crush on Seahawk." Glimmer shrugs, turning to look at what's missing on the deck.

"You know I assume Mermista and Seahawk are coming when you say 'usual people' right? And that I like seeing both of them?" Adora raises an eyebrow at Glimmer.

"I know, I just like making sure you know." Glimmer, as always, is too protective of Adora. She palms her forehead. "Oh! Scorpia is bringing an old friend. Sounds like she had a nasty breakup and moved here from Fright City. Doesn't have a lot of friends."

"Oh, well hopefully she fits in with us misfits." She jokes. They can be a hard group to break into, with so many inside jokes and traditions nestled in even the most unlikely places.

"Well, Im going to play with my best friend so you and Bow can finish setting up," Adora says, eyeing Angel hiding behind a chair .

Glimmer glances at her gratefully and Adora knows she's been let off the hook for now. "That would be amazing Dora , I still have so much to prep." She hustles back into the house.

Without warning she runs towards Angel, making him squeal. "Tag you're it!" Adora pats Angel's head and then runs, hearing his screeching giggle as he chases her.

Within an hour almost everyone arrives, Scorpia and Perfuma are the only ones missing.

"Do you think the love birds got sidetracked on their way here?" Spinerella speculates.

Netossa waggles her eyebrows at her wife. "I wouldn't doubt it. They've been stretching out that honeymoon period."

Adora shakes her head at the pair. "Nah, Glimmer said they were bringing a friend, they probably are picking her up or something," She says, keeping an eye on Angel to make sure that he stays far from his dad at the barbeque.

"Oh, so they are bringing a girl with them? You interested Dora? I can wing woman for you." Netossa offers with a smirk.

Adora sighs. "No, Im not interested. Im happy as I am." Adora tries her best to avoid thinking about Catra when the topic of dating comes up and she's mostly successful.

Adora rough houses with Angel some, hoping to tire him out so he can turn in early today. She's carrying him on her back when Scorpia and Perfuma show up, *Catra* of all people following closely behind them. Adora can't help but gawk at her . She is wearing less than Adora has ever seen before, in a crop top shirt and a pair of the tiniest shorts known to humankind.

Adora almost drops Angel off her back, quickly compensating and swinging him onto her hip, earning a little yelp from the child in question.

Scorpia flags everyone down, and the group approaches her, most curious about the newcomer. Adora's brain hasn't caught up with the rest of her yet, still staring awestruck at her... friend? Friend. She hopes anyway.

Scorpia puffs herself up, looking even taller than usual. "This is Catra, everybody! She's my friend from back home I have been telling you all about. I told her that she's more than welcome here, and we are all going to have a great time!" It kind of sounds like when a teacher is pushing kids together in a group project, overenthusiastic and peppy.

Adora catches Catra's grimace at Scorpia's exuberance. Before Scorpia can make introductions, Catra zeroes in on Adora. She smirks as she eyes Adora up and down. "Hey Adora." She has never heard her name sounds like that. Adora can feel herself blushing from the root of her hair.

"Hi, Cat. Good to see you." Adora walks right up to Catra, she can't help but stand close, especially now that there's no bar between them.

Scorpia gasps like she's watching the climax of an action movie. "Oh gosh, what a small world! I can't believe you know Adora, she's the best!" She gushes, clapping her hands together .

"Dora is pretty great," Catra says offhandedly, ruffling Adora's hair. Angel immediately reaches up and grabs Catra's hand out of Adora's hair and straight into his own curls.

Catra laughs eyeing Angel. She acquiesces and ruffles Angel's hair too while Adora tries not to be jealous of a four-year-old. "And who is this cheeky kid?" Catra gives Angel an almost tender look, soft in a way that Adora hadn't really seen before.

"Angel." He introduces himself, holding out his hand like Bow taught him. Instead of cooing at him like most people, Catra takes his hand, giving him a firm handshake as if he were an adult.

Angel eyes her for a moment after their very serious handshake. "You pretty." He gives a definitive nod at his observation and gives Catra a toothy smile. Catra struggles to keep a straight face and has to cover her lips with her hand to hide a smile.

Glimmer walks up to them and Adora's head snaps up. She'd kind of forgotten that they had an audience. "That would be my kid. He's something else sometimes. Really, all of the time. Hi, I'm Glimmer."

Glimmer makes to grab Angel from Adora but he burrows his face into Adora's hair. Adora isn't too fond of the idea of letting him go either, the feeling of Angel in her arms grounding her. She tightens her grip on him, sending her friend a warning look.

"Pleasure." Catra replies, humor in her gaze as she eyes Glimmer and then glances back at Adora.

After a moment of silence, Scorpia jumps in and introduces everyone else. "We have Bow, that's Glimmer's husband and Angel's dad." Bow sends a hearty wave from the barbecue and points down at his own crop top in solidarity. Catra gives him a thumbs up.

"Spinerella and Nettossa, and Mermista and Seahawk." Scorpia points at everyone before turning back to her girlfriend. "And Fuma, but you already know her."

Catra snorts. "Oh yeah, I hear about Perfuma, *all* the time." She gives Scorpia a meaningful look and Scorpia turns the color of a crab.

"Hey, Catra. Come with Spinny and me, we'll grab you a beer!" Catra gives Adora a look that asks if she is coming along.

She shifts the toddler on her hip and looks at him. "I'm on kid duty until his parents finish setting up." Adora shrugs apologetically. She leans in to whisper in Catra's ear. "Go make new friends Cat, we'll catch up in a bit."

Catra gives her a glare but it's softened when she glances down at Angel. "Alright take care of the tike." She lets herself get dragged by Spinnerella as Netossa talks her ear off.

Adora pays attention to Angel but she can't help but glance at Catra at every opportunity. She seems to be getting along well with everyone, and all her friends have warmed up to her. At times, Catra catches Adora's glances and throws her a smile. It makes Adora's heart grow in her chest, but she tamps down the reaction. It takes another forty-five minutes of watching Angel for Bow to give Seahawk reins of the grill and come grab his kid.

"Thanks for watching him, Adora." Bow smiles gratefully. He turns his attention to Angel. "But now we are going to have super awesome dad time, right?"

Angel nods excitedly and starts running around the yard as Bow takes off after him. The moment she is alone, she feels a stare on her back that could only be Catra's. It makes the hairs on the back of her neck stand up and a shiver run down her spine. She turns to see Catra finish walking toward Adora in the corner of the yard.

The moment she reaches Adora she blurts out, "I'm sorry if this is weird for you, I didn't know you'd be here." Catra seems worried, a stark difference from their light banter earlier.

"Why would it be weird Cat?" Adora asks, eyebrows pulling together. She knows they've danced around the idea of hanging out outside of the bar, but Adora thought ~~she'd~~ *hoped* ~~that~~ it was only a matter of time before they broke the holding pattern they had been sitting in.

"We've never hung outside the bar before." Catra points out the obvious, before getting gunshy. "And you know, what happened a

few weeks ago."She gives Adora a heavy look, referring to Adora's attempt to ask her out.

Adora sighs, grabbing Catra's hand. She ignores her racing heart rate. Comforting Catra is more important. "Catra listen to me. Really listen."Adora waits until she sees Catra looking straight at her . "I want to be your friend. I'd been meaning to ask if you wanted to hang out, but I didn't want to come across as pushy ."Adora says seriously. She always felt so greedy for Catra's time and attention, she was never sure where the line was between moving their friendship forward and pressing against Catra's unspoken boundaries. "I'm not gonna drop your friendship because you don't want to date me. I'm a big girl."Adora jokes. She makes a show of flexing her arm obnoxiously .

"I can't date anyone right now ."Catra corrects gently , her split eyes warm. She's just so *close* only a few feet from Adora, and it's fucking with her brain.

Adora shakes her head. "Whatever the case is, we're friends Cat and I would love for you to be friends with my friends. Makes my life easier."She grins. If Catra's okay with this, it's really the best-case scenario. She'd be able to see Catra more often if she'd come by with Scorpia and that could only be a plus in Adora's book.

She watches Catra's shoulder relax slightly . "Okay , cool. I just wanted to make sure we were good."She says looking down at her clasped hands.

"Of course we're good. No reason not to be."Adora reassures her . She knows it might have come about in an odd way, but Catra's friendship means a lot to her, more than any attempt at romance.

"Alright then."Catra shoots her a conspiratorial look. "Since we're good, give me the skinny on everyone."

"I mean Spinny and T ossa have been together for God knows how long."She actually isn't even sure how the older couple met. "Same

with Glim and Bow. They saw each other's soul marks the first day of kindergarten and were inseparable since."Adora nods at the angel wings that adorn each of their right ankles. Catra nods along.

"I met Glim and Bow in high school. I was pretty lonely back then." Mara had recently passed away and she didn't really have a direction. Finding Glimmer and Bow had been a godsend in so many ways. "We went to college together which is where we met Perfuma and Mermista. You know how Perfuma and Scorpia met I'm assuming."Catra rolls her eyes and gives her an exasperated look. Adora laughs. "And Mermista met Seahawk on a boat charter of all places. Wasn't even looking for her soulmate at the time."Adora thinks of mentioning that she and Mermista were dating at the time, but it feels like a weird tidbit to include.

"That's her soulmate? Not a fuckbuddy?"Catra's tone is dubious as she looks at Mermista hovering over Seahawk to make sure he doesn't set their food on fire.

"Yeah, Merms is just hard to read but she loves him. He's good for her."Adora means that. She thinks she might be the person who best knows how much Mermista loves Seahawk.

"Well, if my soulmate was going to be like that, I'm glad I haven't met them."Catra whispers low in Adora's ear .

Adora laughs, shaking her head at Catra. "Well, whoever they are they wouldn't be like Seahawk because your soulmate is meant to be your match, not anyone else's."A sigh escapes her as she says a line she knows by heart. "My mom used to say that to me."She shares, looking out at her friends.

"Used to?"Catra must pick up something in her voice.

Her smile wobbles. "Yeah. She died while I was in high school. Car accident."Adora looks down at the ground, counting grass blades.

"Oh Dor Im so sorry ."Catra reaches out and puts a hand on her shoulder. The weight of her hand feels right there.

"It's ok. I mean obviously , it was devastating but it was worse for my other mom. She never really recovered from losing her soulmate you know?"She thinks of how lonely Hope must be now especially since Adora moved to Bright Moon. Razz is around but it's not the same, wandering her house alone, no one else there. "Makes you feel different about soulmates. It isn't all good. Like everything in life, there are risks to it."Adora touches the hand Catra has placed on her shoulder.

"I hear that. Y ou know that if you need anything, you can count on me right?"Catra asks, eyes searching Adora's. She feels warm all over. It's the first time Catra has really extended an of fer for that type of intimacy.

"Of course."She says with a smile because she's never doubted that if she needs Catra she can count on her. Adora clears her throat, shifting in her place to look at Catra. "Especially if I need a drink, right?"Adora teases.

Catra let her get away with lightening the mood, shoving Adora's shoulder playfully. "Let me mix you a drink and you'll be well on your way to being drunk, blondie."

Adora grins. "I look forward to the challenge Cat."

"Adora. When did you meet such a hottie? Why did you not tell me?" Glimmer whispers urgently. She pulls Adora aside while everyone watches Catra doing tricks with the liquor bottles. Seahawk in particular seems mesmerized.

"At a bar , a few months ago. She works there." Adora tells her . Glimmer looks about to burst so Adora holds a hand up to stop her. "I was just in a rough spot after I lost my soul mark."Glimmer gives her a sad look her eyes almost instantly shining with tears. "I

didn't want to talk about it with you because I knew you would give me that face."She scrambles to rearrange her face from dripping with pity. "At first, it felt weird to talk about because we weren't even friends but then we were friends and it felt weird to say that I had been going to a bar every week for months without mentioning it?" Adora tries.

Glimmer pats Adora's hand consoling her. "I knew you were working on your own stuff Adora Im glad that you had someone to help."She looks back at Catra. "Especially such a hot someone."She raises an eyebrow at Adora. "Now, when are you gonna ask her out?There's so much *tension* between you two. I feel hot just thinking about it." Glimmer makes a show of fanning her cheeks.

"I already did,"Adora admits shyly, "she let me down easy, and said she wants to be friends."Adora can't help the twinge she feels thinking about it.

Glimmer hums. "I mean, Scorpia did say she had a nasty breakup. Maybe something could happen later?"Her eyes scream excitement as she keeps sending covert looks Catra's way.

"Maybe, but I wouldn't bank on it. Glim, Im not going to be some creep that waits around or whatever. Catra's awesome and Ill be glad to be her friend."Adora knows there is an attraction between them—she'd have to be dead not to recognize it—but that doesn't mean Catra owes her anything.

"Yeah, I get you."Glimmer looks past Adora for a moment and smirks. "Well look at that."She shifts Adora so she can see Mermista and Catra chatting amicably. Seems Catra finished showing off her bar tricks. Seahawk joins them and Catra wrinkles her nose like she smells something distasteful. "You clearly have a type Ador."

Adora flushes at that. "Mermista and Catra don't look anything alike," Adora whispers, praying no one else hears.

"They both have *attitudes*." Glimmer grins knowingly. "Why don't we go talk to them?"

She starts to lead Adora towards them and Adora digs her heels. She feels weird about talking with Mermista and Catra at the same time.

"I'm gonna go help Bow!" Adora tries to move towards the barbeque but she holds on. Glimmer, for being such a tiny thing, has a grip of steel and completely ignores Adora's protestations. The group looks up as Adora and Glimmer make it across the backyard. Catra and Mermista both smirk at Adora and Seahawk beams.

"Hey, guys! What are you up to here?" Glimmer saddles up to them trying to be casual and largely failing.

"I was wondering if the most illustrious Catra would deign me the honor of teaching me her most challenging tricks with spirits," Seahawk says training his puppy dog eyes on Catra. They are less than effective, the brunette eyeing him dismissively.

"And *I* was telling Seahawk here that I'm not gonna do that, given that he needs parental supervision to stand at the barbeque." Catra counters, sickly sweet as she smiles at the man in question.

"This doesn't involve fire! It should be fine!" Seahawk insists.

Catra rolls her eyes. "Alcohol is flammable boss. And I don't trust you." She gives Seahawk a judgy look from head to toe.

"I like her," Mermista announces, giving Adora a *look*. She has no idea what that's supposed to mean.

"I mean I can bully your boy here whenever you need. That I'll do for free." Seahawk visibly deflates as Mermista grins. "Like those boat shoes. Why are you wearing those?" Catra goes for serious but her eyes tighten with amusement.

"Yeah, Hawk, want to tell Catra why you are wearing those?" Seahawk actually glares at Mermista, a rare sight.

"The shoes you wanted me to wear weren't better!" He protests, cheeks flushing red.

"I haven't seen them and I can guarantee they are." Catra digs with a smirk.

Mermista and Catra get a few more swipes in until Glimmer and Catra get into a deep discussion about Catra's shoes and where she got them.

Mermista steps closer to Adora. "Is this the girl from the phone?" She whispers to Adora. She scratches her neck and nods hesitantly. "Keep her D[illegible], she's fun." The words are casual but Mermista's warm tone and the way she squeezes Adora's shoulder say something different.

"She isn't mine to keep," Adora whispers back, a reminder both for herself and her ex

Mermista rolls her eyes. "Yeah, yeah, sell that shit to Glimmer and Bow. I have eyes." Adora ignores Mermista when Catra gives Adora a curious look.

"Catra and I are going shopping next weekend and you aren't invited." Glimmer says point blank.

Adora is taken aback at how she could have missed *that* much conversation. "When did this happen? Why am I specifically uninvited?"

Mermista gives her a heavy glare. "I wouldn't wish going shopping with you on my worst enemy—you're such a brat about it D[illegible]." Adora opens her mouth to say something but she really has no defense. She *hates* shopping. She doesn't see the point in trying on

so many things and running around a bunch of stores to end up with the same type of shirts she always wears.

Catra's eyes are amused as she looks Adora up and down for what feels like the hundredth time that day. "I kind of want to see it. I can't imagine Adora being a brat about something." Adora feels herself blush at Catra's tone.

"It's probably for the best that you don't." She's happy to be Catra's friend but she shouldn't torture herself with a day of watching Catra try on clothes. Who knows what type of delights turned to horrors would be waiting for her, if the amount of skin Catra is showing now is any indication.

"Burgers are out! The second batch of burgers for repeats!" Bow calls out. He's looking straight at Adora, a knowingly look as he waves at her with his spatula. She is just getting dragged by everyone today, isn't she?

"On it," she calls. She walks towards the grill, grabs a plate, and lets Bow serve her a couple of burgers. She takes the opportunity to work with Bow, helping him finish off the burgers on the grill and setting aside a few extras in case anyone got hungry.

He looks like he is about to explode when he finally cracks. "Okay, what's up with you and the new girl, I *need* to know." Bow whispers while handing over her plate.

Adora groans. She doesn't have the mental space to explain Catra again to anyone else. "Glimmer will fill you in. We're friends." Bow makes a disappointed noise. Adora looks at Catra who is now sitting with Netossa and Spinerella again, a sleepy Angel on her lap.

Catra throws her head back in a laugh at something Netossa says but quickly quiets and rubs Angel's arm when he scrunches his face at the noise.

"She really fits in with us," Bow says, giving Adora a sidelong look.

"Yeah, she does," Adora whispers. She can't imagine a way Catra doesn't fit in with her.

Picking up after a barbeque is no joke and Adora is determined to make it less difficult for her friends, given that they usually host. She gravitates toward Catra again, finding herself next to the brunette without really meaning to. "Did you have a good time?" She asks once most everyone has left. She walks Catra to the door, Scorpia and Perfuma already settling into the car.

"Yeah, your people are cool." She pauses for a moment, eyeing Adora. "I'm glad Scorpia has Perfuma. They are good together." The word soulmate stays unsaid between them this time.

"You know, we can hang out not on Wednesdays if you want." Adora ventures. Now that Catra knows most of her social group, it feels like something has shifted. She can't put her finger on it, but she knows spending more time with Catra is worth the risk.

Catra smiles wide. "I'd like that." She looks up at Scorpia waving her away. "Call me and we'll figure it out." She offers. She hesitates for a moment, then reaches out and grabs Adora's hand, squeezing it gently as a goodbye.

Adora waits until Scorpia's car drives away to close the door and help Glimmer and Bow with clean up. Her hand is warm and her shoulder kind of burns. She doesn't think much of it.

Chapter End Notes

> I am running on zero sleep because of the Taylor Swift album release and this almost didn't get posted again because my brain just wants me to write like 18.4 Catradora fic based on Midnights. However, I pulled away just enough to edit this mostly complete chapter lol. Let me know what you think now that Catra and Adora have met and hung out outside the bar!

Also, I hit 100k hits on AO3 TODAY and I am super overwhelmed by the support. I would give you all high-fives, waves, or hugs depending on your comfort level (Probably best to stick with just doing fanfiction though lol).

Kudos and comments make the world go round. Please also follow on Twitter if you want to see content like the polls I have right now to figure out which Midnights track Ill focus on as inspiration for a one-shot!

I posted this one-shot last week which I think is pretty funny, feel free to check it out!

Next week: Chapter 2 of my personal favorite, Paradigm Shift!

Next time in Burnt into My Skin: our girls go kayaking.

Chapter 5

Chapter Summary

Kayaking with the girls.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"I think I'm never going to have Adora's undivided attention again for as long as I live." Glimmer sighs dramatically , talking to no one as she looks at Adora. Bow had stepped away to make sure Angel got a nap in before they met up with their other friends later.

Adora clears her throat, internally cursing being caught on her phone when she's supposed to be present, listening to Glimmer vent about a work conflict.

"I swear that I'll stop now ." She says and she puts down her phone on the table. She feels guilt tug at her as she looks up at her best friend. "Really . It's shitty of me."

Glimmer rolls her eyes. "Relax Adora you didn't murder anyone." She smirks as she looks down at Adora's phone sitting between them. "Besides, I get it. I bet it's Catra right?"

Adora can feel her face heat up at the mention of the other woman. "No." She lies, feeling a little embarrassed. Catra's been back to hang with her friends a few times but nowhere near enough to be considered part of the social circle.

At that moment, her phone buzzes and her eyes fly down, looking at the texts coming in and popping up on her screen. She resists the urge to read it and looks back up at Glimmer.

"Uh-huh. Definitely not Catra." Glimmer teases lightly. Adora doesn't know how she manages to take a drink from her cup while looking smug, but Glimmer finds a way.

Adora groans and caves, snatching up her phone. "Okay yes. It's Catra. The bar's slow today, she usually can't text me during her shifts." She isn't even sure how Catra does it; the bar owner seems to have an eagle eye for anything that goes against the rules. One time she caught Adora trying to come around the bar and honestly, Adora isn't sure if she was more intimidated or turned on by the hulking woman.

"Ha! Called it." Glimmer says as Adora fires off a quick text back before pocketing her phone, resolutely ignoring the way it vibrates the moment she slips it away. Glimmer eyes her for a moment, her short hair bobbing when she tilts her head. "You sure there's nothing there?" She asks, not for the first time. To Glimmer's credit, she hasn't been pushy about Catra, but she hasn't let it go either.

"Yeah, I'm sure." Adora crosses one of her arms and reaches out for her own drink with the other. She and Catra are clearly and exclusively friends, and it was *fine*. Catra turned her down and she isn't going to ruin what was quickly becoming one of her most rewarding relationships by being greedy.

"You know, when I went shopping with her, Catra asked a lot about you." Glimmer says it casually, but her raised eyebrow and calculating stare tell a different story.

Adora can't even hope to not react to that. "She did?" She asks eagerly. Glimmer had been suspiciously hush-hush about the whole shopping trip, and it was driving Adora up the wall. The fact that *Glimmer* of all people got to hang out one on one with Catra and she hadn't yet didn't help.

"Yeah. Almost everything leads back to what you thought about something or another." She smiles warmly. "I like Catra. She's funny and seems like a good person. Fits in with the group."

"I like her too," Adora admits, not for the first time. It was impossible not to notice how amazing Catra is and the connection there. "But we're better as friends."

Glimmer sighs. "Okay , I want to ask you something and it isn't Catra related. Or I guess it could be, but it doesn't have to be?" She says uncertainty. She stops for a moment, looking down at her hands. "We've talked about soulmates before. And I know you don't think you'll meet yours. Are you interested in romance and finding someone right now? Even if it isn't your soulmate?"

"This isn't about Catra?" She asks suspiciously .

Glimmer shrugs. "It isn't unless you say it is. I'm not assuming it is at any rate." Adora doubts that, but she lets it go.

Adora sighs and lets herself think about it. "I honestly don't know . So many people act like once you're thirty and you lose your mark it's all over. There was so much anxiety to getting here that after didn't really concern me much."

A guilty look crosses Glimmer's face. "I can see that. I guess Bow and I didn't help on that front." Almost as if being called forward, Bow steps out from the hallway that leads to the bedrooms of their house.

He eyes the pair with concern, his steps slowing as he takes them in. "Sorry , Angel gave me a hard time falling asleep. If you want, I can go and hang out in the backyard if you need a minute." Bow offers quietly as he looks between the two women.

Adora waves him off. "I don't mind. We were talking about soulmates." The *again* goes without saying.

Bow nods and sits down. "Alright."

She holds her hands together. "I guess now I don't have the expectation and I'm free to do what want. At least, that's how I see it." Ultimately , a soulmate would just be a reminder of everything she

stood to lose if anything went wrong. Without that person, she could forge her own path. "So, I could be open to finding someone. I think if it's meant to be itll happen."

Glimmer shoots her an incredulous look. "Y ou do see how ironic that statement is, right?"

Adora laughs, surprising herself. This is the lightest she's felt talking about soulmates in a long time. "Y eah, I guess. Soulmates are the epitome of If it' s meant to be."She concedes. "But I meant it in a different way. Less that the universe has someone out there for me and I just have to wait and more that if the right person and I cross paths well figure it out together ."

"It could be any right person."Bow muses. "That does sound liberating."

Glimmer nudges his shoulder, giving him a doting smile. "Y eah, tired of being with me after this long."She teases.

Bow rolls his eyes but wraps his arms around her, placing a soft kiss on her cheek. "Never ."He swears.

"Gross, you two."Adora rolls her eyes but it' s mostly for show. Hanging around these two has made her mostly immune to their sappy displays.

"W ell, Im glad youre open to loving someone if the right person came your way."Glimmer says, holding Bow' s hand and squeezing it softly. She then smirks at Adora. "On a totally unrelated note, when Catra and I went shopping she got black lingerie and asked me what you might think of it."

Just the thought makes Adora feel like a sinner in church. "She didnt!"There is a zero chance that Catra did that, but she can almost imagine it in her mind's eye. Catra's split eyes are so expressive it blows her mind sometimes how much she can convey

with them. She'd look at Adora so coy it would make her start sweating before her eyes could even trail lower—

"No, she didn't do that." Glimmer agrees. "But it was too good to not say."

"Glimmer ." She wishes she could somehow make her cheeks not feel like they were on fire. "You hate me." She's not sure why she's best friends with someone so cruel.

She rolls her eyes. "You'll get over it." She then gives Adora a knowing stare. "Also, if you want, you can answer Catra's text."

Adora refuses to be embarrassed by how fast she whips her phone out to look at what Catra last sent her. "Love you, Glim."

Bow laughs but Adora doesn't bother looking up from her screen.

Perfuma seems to be struggling with a larger volume so Adora quickly grabs it before she can drop it. She sends Adora a relieved smile, directing her to put the book on the top shelf.

"I'm glad that you swung by , Adora." She sounds a bit out of breath. Adora surmises that she must have been putting up some of the new inventory.

Perfuma's bookshop was a cozy place. She stocked books and teas which made for a relaxing experience. One of their go-to hangouts is for Adora to swing by on one of the slower shifts but she hadn't done it in ages.

"Well, I'm glad I got here before you dropped that book on your feet." She smiles easily. "Have time for a break?"

Perfuma nods, setting down the few books she had left. "I'll get us some tea." They walk to the small lounging area near the back of the bookstore where she has a little tea dispenser. Adora finds a snug

chair as she waits. She's always enjoyed the cool greens and rich dark woods of the place, but she noticed some of the décor has changed, splashes of pink and white making an appearance in some spots.

Perfuma hands her a piping hot mug and Adora carefully sets it down, watching the little plumes of smoke until it's stable on the coffee table between them.

"How have you been? We haven't really had one on one time lately." Perfuma says right before taking a sip. Adora doesn't know how she hasn't burned her tongue yet.

"Well, a lot has been going on. It happens." Adora allows.

Perfuma shoots her a stern look. "Yes, but at least on my end, it's not an excuse. Although having Scorpia in my life has been a blessing, I don't want finding my soulmate to weaken my other meaningful bonds with people." She explains.

Adora nods. It's the type of sensible take she expects from Perfuma. "I see your point." She grins. "So how is soulmate life treating you?" Her thoughts of Scorpia naturally lead to the shadow of a thought of someone else, but she sets that aside.

Perfuma looks cautious as her grip tightens on her mug. "Are you sure you'd want to talk about it, Adora?" She asks tentatively.

She nods, for a moment rubbing her hand against her shoulder. The pain has subsided but sometimes, it feels almost like a phantom limb, like she'll see her mark if she pulls up her sleeve. "Yeah, it doesn't bother me. I'm happy for you." She really is and she had been since before she lost her mark.

Perfuma sighs dreamily, eyes far off as she sets down her mug. "Well, it's everything I thought it would be and more. I would say that I wish we would have met sooner but I think that we met at exactly

the right time.” Her smile is bright like constellations, the moon in her eyes.

Adora juts out her lower lip. “Yeah? Why?”

“When I was younger, I wouldn’t have been ready for this type of commitment. It can be daunting.” Perfuma smiles serenely. “But now that I’ve lived and reflected more, I realize that it’s what I want. I’m so happy I found her.”

Adora picks up her mug, taking a cautious sip of its contents small frown on her face. Before Scorpia, Perfuma was a lot like her—rapidly approaching thirty and no soulmate in sight. She’d been more into the idea than Adora was, but she wasn’t exactly Glimmer and Bow. To see her guard down and gushing about it feels like a one-eighty.

“You look like you have something on your mind,” Perfuma notes, eyes roving between Adora’s face and her tea mug.

“I recently chatted with Glimmer about soulmates. I think we just see it so different for lots of reasons but in part because she’s always had Bow, and she’s never really grappled with losing that outside of the hypothetical.”

“Has Glimmer been upsetting you?” Perfuma asks quickly, something flashing in her eyes.

“No. Well, no more so than usual.” She admits. She’s not sure that soulmates will ever be a topic that isn’t sore between them but she’s happier with the steps Glimmer has taken to understand her. “You know how on my case Bow and Glimmer were, but they’ve been trying to see my perspective. And I think we’ve made progress.”

“So, what’s troubling you?” She prompts.

“I’m just wondering if you ever felt like the soulmate thing was a lot. You know, maybe stifling.”

She's never really talked about that aspect of how she feels about soulmates with anyone but maybe Perfuma would understand.

Instead, Perfuma gives her a confused look. "Not suffocating, but definitely it's challenging. I think when you find the right person the obstacles just don't feel like they are obstacles at all anymore."

"And that right person is your soulmate?" She challenges.

Perfuma bites her lip. "Well, yes. For me at least. I'm sure people can have other journeys."

She bites her lip and nods. She thought maybe Perfuma would get it but now she isn't so sure. "Alright." She takes another sip from her tea. "What blend is this anyway?"

Perfuma happily launches into an explanation and Adora determines to ignore the way her gut clenched and just enjoy an afternoon with her friend.

"Did Perfuma give you the tea I told you about?" Adora grins widely, leaning on the bar top. She feels a thump come from her side and notices the bar owner giving her a glare. She quickly moves her elbows off the counter, apparently something that isn't allowed even though *it's a bar*.

Catra laughs at how quickly Adora reacts. "Yes, she did, it was really good." She assures. She steps away for a moment to provide a beer to another customer before coming back. She hums thoughtfully, but her eyes are pure mischief. "You know, I still can't believe you were more scared of a TV show than a literal kid was."

"It's because he doesn't understand the nuance yet! And I have anxiety about pest issues." She defends.

She knew the moment that show came on while they were hanging out with everyone that Catra was going to taunt her mercilessly.

Adora cant help the way she shudders just thinking about all matter of creepy crawlies that were infesting people's homes in that bad daytime television series.

"Relax, princess. Ill kill any scary bugs in your house." She offers, leaning across the bar. Adora notes with some displeasure that *Catra* doesnt get a warning thump from the bar owner.

"So, say we are hanging out. Where would we go?" Catra asks shyly.

It takes a minute to realize that Catra means hanging out just them two, but once she does, Adora perks up. "We could do whatever you wanted." She offers. "Im pretty flexible."

Catra's lips twitch at that. "Not in front of the children." She gasps, eyes too round to be expressing real shock.

Adora cant help but smile even though it was a bad joke. "Catra. Were at a bar." She points out unnecessarily.

Catra drops her fake outrage. "It's funnier when Angel is here to back me up." The last time Catra went to Glimmer's Angel acted like a laugh track to all of Catra's jokes which was both endlessly cute and terrible for Adora's sanity.

Adora waivers for a moment. "Well figure out something to do together?" She broaches the subject again before it gets lost to their Wednesday night banter.

Adora feels like the only person on the planet when Catra smiles at her, so soft it doesnt feel real. "Yeah. Well do something just us." A loud ring shatters the moment. "That's your mac and cheese and popcorn shrimp." She sighs. "Be right back."

The loudness of the bar fills her senses again as Catra walks away but she doesnt quite mind it. Nothing could detract from the warmth in her chest.

It takes them two weeks to figure out what to do, but they decide to go kayaking. Catra is the one that suggests it, so Adora doesn't feel bad when she tells Catra that there's a place she'd been thinking about taking her anyway.

Adora loves being out on the lake on days like his where the water is so still paddling is like running a knife through butter. "Adora you're like an engine. Am I not supposed to row with you?" Catra complains as she turns her head so she can look at Adora from the corner of her eye.

Adora easily paddles out without Catra moving a finger. "I mean if you want, you can paddle. Or you can lean back and relax while I ferry you around the lake." Adora grins. "You know, really lean into that day off."

Catra shoots Adora a glare. "I'm going to let you tire yourself out, then I'll rescue you when you can't get us back to shore." She huffs.

Adora snorts. Catra sets her paddle down and leans back, cushioning her head on one of Adora's thighs. Adora's breath stutters and she paddles faster. She tries to distract herself from the feeling of Catra's overflowing hair in her lap.

"I'm practically just rowing my own body weight. You're tiny, Cat." She can't help but tease.

Catra cracked an eye open to glare up at Adora. She's even cute upside-down.

"I'm a grown woman and I refuse to dignify that with a response." Catra harrumphs, then shifts, reminding Adora that she's using her thigh as a pillow. "So, when did you get into water sports anyway, little mermaid?"

"I'm not the little mermaid." She rolls her eyes. She wishes she had a free hand to maybe poke Catra's nose or something, but it's probably for the best that she has to keep her hands to herself. "I

used to live by a little stream, got my mom so mad when I'd jumped in. Always loved the water."

At first, they have a quiet conversation, but it slowly dies into a comfortable silence. Catra ends up dozing off, her head still in Adora's lap. Adora paddles through the lake, enjoying the breeze. She looks down at Catra occasionally, noticing the way the sun plays on her face. Her eyelashes are full, casting long shadows over her cheeks.

When Adora finally finds a good spot on the edge of the lakeshore, she gently touches Catra's hairline near her forehead. She scrunches up her face, moving away from Adora's touch and she has to contain a coo.

"Hey sleepy, wake up." She says gently. Catra's eyes go wide, and she shoots straight up, upsetting the balance of the kayak for a moment. "Catra! Chill!" Adora calls out gripping the sides of the kayak while thinking stable thoughts.

The kayak stops moving and Catra turns her head to look Adora in the eyes. "I'm *so* sorry I fell asleep on you and almost turned over the kayak just now." She spits out quickly, a blush rising to her cheeks. Her hair looks wilder than normal billowing in the breeze.

Adora smiles easily. "It's fine, I actually had a surprise for you, so it worked out."

Catra crosses her arms, but Adora can't see her face given that she's facing away and sitting up. "A surprise? Out here?" Her tone is dubious at best.

"Yeah, turn around." She encourages.

Catra throws an exasperated look over her shoulder. "Adora, we're on a kayak that almost tipped over just now."

Adora snorts. "And you're small, just move slow . It'll be fine." Catra huffs but complies. She carefully turns until she's facing Adora.

She pulls open her bag with a flourish, revealing a bunch of snacks. "T a-da! I figured we might get hungry , so I brought some chips and sandwiches."

Catra smiles and reaches into Adora's bag, but she stops midway there. "Adora." She says slowly . "Are we on a date?"

Adora raises her eyebrow at the question. "Um, no Cat, we aren't. Why do you ask?" At one time she envisioned showing Catra this spot on a date, but really, she just wanted to show Catra a place she loved.

Catra waves her arms around as if that makes things clearer. "Y ou know! Picnic on a lake with a sunset." She points at each component in turn.

"Okay , I see your point. But you can ask Scorp~~me~~ carrying food to friend activities is a given most of the time. You know I'm always hungry." Adora points out. Catra nods and sneaks in a quick eye roll. "Also, you fell asleep and drooled on my leg I don't think that's very date-like." She teases.

Catra rolls her eyes. Adora reaches out for Catra's hand, serious this time. "But most importantly , you told me you didn't want to go on a date, Cat. I'm not going to sneak you onto a date. That's not who I am."

Catra relaxes slightly , her shoulders dropping as she looks away momentarily. "I know you wouldn't D r , it just suddenly felt romantic and I'm not sure if I'm being fair to you or sending mixed signals." Catra is grabbing both of her hands now, her frame smaller as she folds into herself.

"Y ou aren't sending me mixed signals Catra. Y ou told me you don't want to go on a date, and we didn't and now we're just hanging out. I

have definitely done with Glimmer and Bow before."Adora points out. "Although, I've never taken them here."

"Why not? It's gorgeous."

Adora takes a look around the quiet and wilderness, a place that feels hers even though it's so much bigger than she is. "This is a place I like to go to think. Somewhere I can be alone. It felt okay to share with you because I thought you might get it."She offers. It's not a full explanation of how she feels here, but she hopes to be understood.

Catra's eyes flash and she takes a long look at the scenery before looking back at Adora and nodding. "I do. Thanks for sharing."She says softly.

"If I ever feel like you aren't being fair to me, I'll say so okay?"She adds, reaching out and placing a hand on Catra's knee.

Catra looks up from her lap. "That would make me feel better."She admits. Her shoulders bunch up again as she searches Adora's gaze. It makes Adora worry her lip. "I'm not sure what Scorpia said about my move to Bright Moon?"Catra starts tentatively.

"She said you had a bad breakup. That's pretty much all, to be honest."Adora says readily.

Catra looks back down at her lap as she starts to talk, the words choppy and tense. "My ex-girlfriend, Lonnie, and I—we were friends since high school. Even before she was my girlfriend, she was a big part of my life."Adora nods along, not sure where this is going. "We were together for four years and we were committed to each other. Or at least I thought we were."

Catra looks back down at her lap playing with the frayed edge of her shorts. "Neither of us really cared about soulmates, we had each other."She bites her lip and her eyes well with tears. Adora itches to

reach out and comfort her more, but she just tightens the hand that' s still on Catra's knee.

"I'd been planning on bringing up maybe having a kid. I really thought everything was going so well, you know?" Catra's voice cracks as she speaks, a hoarse laugh of disbelief echoing in the background. Adora felt a pit open in her stomach guessing what came next. "Then one day , her soul mark burned and that was it. She barely said two words to me before she moved out." Catra lets out another wet laugh. "Turns out Lonnie has *two* soulmates, not just one. The three of them are getting married next summer ."

Adora reaches out to grab Catra's hand, squeezing it. "Oh Cat. Im so sorry." Adora isn't sure what else she could say about a situation like that.

Catra looks up at Adora again, her eyes burning. "I just felt like I kept dancing around it and I wanted to give an explanation of why Im saying no." Catra rubs her thumb over the back of Adora's hand. She looks away again. "I mean Im over her . It's not that. It's just—I don't know that I can trust someone like that again you know?" Catra's eyes beg her to understand.

Adora does. "Of course. How do you trust something will last when there is an amorphous someone out there that could take it away." She supplies. It's different from her worries but at the root, Adora knows loss well.

Catra nods. "And I know that, for both of us, the chances are low for us even finding *them* but I just—I don't think I could bear to go through that with you. If we dated, I mean."

Adora nods her heart thumping loud as she offers vulnerability in kind. "After my mom died, I was terrified of finding my soulmate. Scared silly that I would connect with someone just to lose them." Adora looks out at the lake, at the sun slowly hiding behind the horizon. "I'm glad I didn't find them." She admits it to herself and to

Catra at the same time, this burgeoning realization waiting to be discovered.

For a moment, it's just stillness and the purple-pink hues of the sunset, slowly covering them, freezing the panorama into art.

"So, we both have shitty feelings around soulmates. We're some pair huh?" Catra says with a light sniffle, her tears gone.

Adora lets out a small chuckle. "That's true." She acknowledges. She makes sure to catch Catra's eyes for this part. She needs Catra to *know*. "Cat I'm not sitting here waiting for you to change your mind about what you want. You're my friend and my life has been so much better since you came into it. I need you to believe that."

Catra looks almost ashamed at her own vulnerability. "You've never done anything to make me believe differently, Adora. I'm sorry if I ruined everything today." Adora shakes Catra's hand out to get her attention.

She then gives her a smile. "Let me eat my chips and then we will see if it's ruined." Adora offers out her backpack again and Catra takes a sandwich and chip bag out.

They eat and watch the sunset together, feeding some ducks that pass by. Turns out, the day isn't ruined after all.

Chapter End Notes

A little more light on where Catra is coming from with this one! Let me know what you think!

We are theoretically more than halfway done! (I'm like 95% sure we are more than halfway anyway).

As always, thoughts, comments, kudos! Engagement makes me happy and I read every single comment and appreciate all of

them with my little gay heart. Follow me on Twitter for more content @esFlower1

NextWeek: We get to chapter 3 of Battle Cry.

Nextime: Catra and Adora go out to the beach with the whole gang and Catra has an important question to ask Adora.

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"How much longer until we get there?" Glimmer says, sounding more like her son than an adult. She's laying down, her head in Bow's lap.

He smiles indulgently at her whining but doesn't answer because no one really knows except Seahawk. The captain had insisted that he wanted to take everyone out on his boat. Now that summer has rolled in and warmed the ocean enough, the group was taking him up on his offer.

"Why so up in arms about it, sparkles?" Catra nudges the sunglasses on her nose to give Glimmer a look. Catra's wearing a big white button-down with most of the buttons undone, her swimwear in full view.

Adora takes in a breath and looks away from the brunette. Summer has been a difficult time for Adora. She's *trying* to be a good platonic friend to Catra, but her wide array of skimpy bikinis has been distracting, to say the least.

"This is the first time I have been to the beach without Angel since he was two!" Glimmer is beyond thrilled that Micah and Angella took Angel for the day. She closes her eyes again, stretching out on the "I love my kid, but I am not wasting the opportunity to suntan *in peace*."

"I hear that, I am not going anywhere near the water." Catra agrees wholeheartedly, sitting up herself. The two share a conspiratorial smile that makes Adora slightly uneasy. Since their shopping trip, Catra and Glimmer became fast friends and one of their favorite activities is making fun of Adora.

"How are you going to get to the shore then?" Adora asks, pointing out the obvious problem with Catra's plan.

She bats her eyelashes at Adora, an exaggerated thing that should not make Adora's gut lurch. "You're just going to have to carry me, blondie." She coos before breaking down into a laugh.

Adora levels a look at Catra. "When you least expect it, I'm going to toss you in the water." She threatens from her seat on the other side of the yacht.

Catra takes off her sunglasses and openly glares at Adora. "Adora, if you wet my curls the only reasonable answer is murder." She says coolly.

Mermista makes a sound of approval, glancing back at them from the helm. "That's so true. God, I can't believe I've been scuba diving right after I did my hair." She groans at the memory, leaning into Seahawk's side.

Bow looks at Seahawk like he's solving a math problem. "Did we ever go scuba diving together? I swear I went with Mermista." He says slowly, trying to recall.

Glimmer sent her husband a glare, slapping his side lightly. "That was *before* we knew Seahawk, Bow." Her look is full of intention and Bow's eyebrow raises slightly when he realizes that he's remembering one of the times he'd been scuba diving with Adora and Mermista on a double date. It was a fun little outing right before their breakup, Adora isn't surprised by the mix-up.

Catra shoots Adora a confused look, clearly looking for context. Adora sighs a little, not knowing how she can possibly explain this to Catra at the moment without making things awkward. She tries to signal Catra with her eyes that they can talk about it later, but she isn't sure the message gets across.

"Oh yeah, you're right." Bow finally says, breaking the small bout of silence. "We should scuba Seahawk, I feel like we'd have a great time." He carries on with little fanfare.

Seahawk's face brightens at the idea.

"No thanks," Mermista answers swiftly before Seahawk can get a word in edgewise. "I trust Adora when scuba diving Hawk...not so much."

Seahawk wilts at his girlfriend's response and Glimmer bites back a laugh. "Yeah, I'd be mildly worried he's gonna drown if we scuba."

"I'd scuba with you, Seahawk." Adora offers, feeling bad for the guy. He's not that much of a menace as long as he isn't around fire anyway.

"You're very gracious Adora." He says with a kind smile. He then looks out at the sea again. "Land ahoy!"

Adora turns her body and looks off the side of the yacht. Sure enough, there's a small island with fine white sand. Seahawk pulls in closer and starts anchoring the yacht relatively close to the shore.

Ultimately, Scorpia ends up carrying Catra onto the shore which is probably better in the long run. Adora's had her fill of the ocean and is back on the shore after about an hour. Now, she's lounging on a chair but she's finding it kind of boring. She wishes she could convince Catra to come to the water with her, but the brunette is resolutely staying dry so far.

"Let's play volleyball." Netossa hollers from a far. She waves everyone forward, herding them towards the part of the beach where she set up a makeshift net.

Adora rolls her eyes. This happens every time they end up near a beach~~s~~ometimes it turns out well, but other times everyone gets

too competitive, and it becomes a fraught battle instead of a few relaxing pick-up games. Given that this is the first time Catra's at the beach with everyone, Adora is hoping it'll be the latter.

"Okay, we need teams! Who's playing and with who?" Spinnerella asks as her eyes dart between likely pairs.

"I'm gonna call wildcat for this. We'll make the best team!" Scorpia immediately partners with Catra, saddling up to her side and pulling her in for a brief hug. Adora is proud to say she feels only mildly put out by this quick partnership.

"Spinnerella and I either have to be on the same team or opposite sides of the bracket because I don't want to fight all day." Netossa laments as she side-eyes her wife, probably wondering if she'll be a friend or foe for the rest of the day.

"There's a bracket?" Catra says with a raised brow, disbelief coloring her voice.

Adora nods. "Netossa is very serious about volleyball. Really, she's serious about anything that can be competitive." She stage whispers to Catra.

"I would rather referee if it's all the same, last time we played volleyball get a little too violent for my taste," Perfuma says primly. Adora holds back a snort—*Perfuma* is the one who made it violent last time.

"Or, am I in for volleyball or a wrestling match?" Catra whispers into Adora's ear while grabbing onto her arm.

Adora bites back a groan at the feeling of Catra's skin. As much as they've hung out in the last few weeks, she's made a careful effort to avoid prolonged physical contact.

"Depends, how good are you at volleyball?" Adora flashes her a grin and Catra laughs, pushing her shoulder.

"I'll be manning my beauty , so I don't have time to play volleyball right now." Seahawk actually bows and walks away in the direction they came from.

Catra looks at Mermista to decipher what Seahawk is talking about but the woman just shrugs. "Seahawk is talking about Dragons Daughter III. I'm pretty sure." Mermista stares after him for a moment and then shrugs, unconcerned.

"Do you want to play with me, dearest?" Spinerella asks with a slight smirk. Netossa nods with a soft smile, wrapping her arms around her wife.

"I'm playing with Glimmy ," Bow says matter-of-factly like they don't always play together.

Mermista locks eyes with Adora, the only other person without a volleyball partner. "I guess that leaves you and me, stranger ." Mermista punches her arm. Adora grins they always make a great volleyball team.

With the teams sorted, the group begins to play. Adora sits on the sand off to the side, digging her hands in the sand as she watches the games. Catra and Scorpia go against Glimmer and Bow for the first round. Adora's eyes are glued to Catra's frame the entire time.

She feels a light nudge on her side. "So, you locked down your girl yet?" Mermista's tone oozes suggestion.

Adora's eyes stay on Catra even as she denies Mermista's implied assumptions. "I have no idea what you are talking about." Catra is good at volleyball for someone so short. She has a really good instinct for where the ball is going to be and does a good job being there first.

"Come on don't play dumb with me Dora." Mermista puts her hand on her hip.

"We're friends." Adora insists.

Her friend snorts. "Friends don't look at each other the way you two do."

Adora eyes Mermista for a moment. She's looking at Adora in a way she knows well. Mermista could be as bullheaded as the day is long when she has a puzzle she thinks she needs to solve. She bites her lip thinking of how much she can say without giving away details Catra rather have private.

"Catra had a bad breakup. It had to do with soulmates." She whispers softly, glad that their other friends are sitting far enough that there's no real danger of eavesdropping. Understanding dawns on Mermista's face, as well as a flash of guilt.

"Oh. Did you talk about us in all that?" Mermista asks delicately after taking a moment to think about it.

The question makes Adora's gut sink. "No. It didn't feel like it was the right moment to bring it up. She was confiding in me. I didn't want to make it about me and what I've been through." She'd revisited that day in her mind, turning over the question of whether she should have told Catra about her breakup with Mermista then.

She nods in agreement, but she gives Adora a weary glance. "Well, maybe you should talk about it. Might make her feel less alone in getting screwed by soulmates?" She suggests.

Adora sighs. "You're right." She concedes. She looks at Mermista again, this time noting how vibrant she seems while still seeming at peace. Adora always thought of Mermista like the ocean—wild, untamable, and ultimately unknowable. She's come to realize that perhaps, Mermista is just unknowable to Adora. "I don't know that I've said this, but I can tell Seahawk is good for you. I know some people don't get it, but I see it Merms."

Mermista blushes furiously which is a feat given her flawless dark skin. "You ever tell him that, I will skin you alive." She threatens eyes darting about to see if someone heard.

Before Adora can respond, she hears Catra's laugh ring clearly across the beach. She looks over to see a fuming Glimmer and Catra sporting a Cheshire cat grin.

"C'mon Glimmer, I'm doing you a favor, you want to go suntan without your kid." Catra reminds her, practically preening.

"Ugh yes, I do. I hate you both though." Glimmer glares at Scorpia and Catra as she stomps off to a beach chair, presumably to tan.

Catra turns to walk off the court, bumping into Adora's leg in the sand as she goes. Adora feels herself flush at the contact. Catra looks at her, her smug look from her victory still present. "Your turn, blondie."

Catra's voice is low and honeyed over making it hard for Adora to think straight. After she snaps out of it, she notices Mermista eyeing her with a look that screams validation.

Adora elbows her. "Shut up, Merms. Let's win this game." Adora stalks onto the sandy court.

"I have a good feeling about this. I know Spinny and I will win it, there's no way we're going out in the first round." Netossa is a continual stream of trash talk.

"We will see about that," Mermista smirks, stretching her arms lazily.

Adora is glad she's playing with Mermista—she's the best volleyball player of the bunch—but every time they do something for the first time since the breakup, there are weird moments. It's so familiar yet different, little details that used to be truths falling away to their new reality.

The game passes in a blur, Adora and Mermista racking up points in record time. Spinerella and Netossa put up a good fight, but the talent disparity is hard to ignore. Adora digs up a low ball, Mermista sets it, and then Adora spikes it directly between Spinerella and Netossa. It's an easy play that they've used dozens of times before.

Spinnerela groans as she stares at the ball and Netossa kicks the sand, cursing under her breath. Catra lets out a low whistle from her beach chair. Adora reaches out to give Mermista a low five, but it doesn't feel natural. When they were together, she might have picked her up over her shoulder in celebration.

"I always said it was unfair that we let you two play volleyball together and I stand by that. Why couldn't you just be bitter exes and play on different teams." Netossa crosses her arms, her short curl bobbing as she shakes her head in disappointment.

Adora laughs at that. "I'm glad that our friendship means that much to you." Adora puts the ball in play again. They smoke Spinnerella and Netossa, as expected.

"What was that? You were going to *win* Netossa?" Mermista jeers, holding her hand up to her ear.

"Ugh, shut it! You played college volleyball, stop picking on me!" Netossa complains although she has no right. They'd won their bragging rights fair and square.

Catra leaves her chair at the commotion, coming to the makeshift court. "College volleyball?" She echoes with her eyes on Mermista.

She grins, leaning the volleyball on her hip like she's posing for an athletic shot. "Yeah, I was pretty good." Mermista pretends to be humble.

Adora rolls her eyes. "She played court volleyball, not beach, so you have a fighting chance." She offers.

"Pf ft doubtful, but Im not a quitter."She eyes the two women briefly before walking toward the other side of the net. Scorpia seems to be done chatting with Perfuma and also heads over to the court, ready for their final volleyball round.

This game is a lot closer than the previous two, mostly because Adora keeps missing balls because of something distracting Catra does. She isnt sure if Catra' s intentionally distracting her and she doesnt know which answer would be worse.

"Adora, I swear if I lose my first game of pick-up volleyball ever because you cant keep your eyes inside your head I will never speak to you again."Mermista screeches as she digs out a ball that Adora sets up.

Mermista spikes it hard, but Scorpia manages to get to it. The rest of the group is watching with avid fascination.

Catra pops it over softly and Adora runs at it and spikes it back just as gently, making it look like she was planning on smacking the ball as hard as possible. Catra ends up in the wrong place because of it and the game is over.

"That was pretty underhanded Dr ."Catra smiles with all her teeth. It looks menacing.

Adora gives her a cocky smile. "I dont think so. And it won us the game, didnt it?"She asks in a singsong voice.

Catra rolls her eyes. "Whatever . Do you want to walk on the beach?" She asks, nodding at the waves.

Adora leans back on her heels, her heart pounding from the serious look on Catra's face. "Sure."She agrees, sending that Catra probably is after more than some hang out time.

They walk close to each other but not touching until they can barely see Seahawk's boat. Catra sits down near the shore and signals for

Adora to sit next to her . She crouches down, mirroring the brunette.

They sit in comfortable silence, cross-legged by the water watching the waves. As the silence continues, Adora starts to relax, thinking she might have overreacted earlier. She considers laying down on the sand when Catra finally speaks up.

"So, you and Mermista?" Catra prompts her eyes on the sand in front of her.

Adora feels stupid for not guessing that Catra would want to talk about that. "I guess you heard Netossa's trash talk?" Adora smiles weakly.

"I mean yeah, but it puts a lot of other things into place too. Why hide it?" Catra sounds hurt.

"I wasn't hiding it from you Cat, it just didn't come up. I honestly thought someone might have said something." It is true to a degree there are plenty of different ways Catra could have found out. "It also never felt like the right time to bring it up on my own."

"So, was it like a college fling or something?" Catra says conversationally, clearly digging for information.

"Um, no actually ." Adora does the math. She buries her fingers in the sand, flexing her hands. "We broke up a year ago now I think?" Her tone is uncertain, she really isn't keeping track. Catra waits patiently as Adora collects her thoughts. "Remember when I told you about how Mermista met Seahawk on a boat charter?" Catra nods. "I was moving Mermista out of our apartment three days after."

Catra gasps, eyes soft with understanding. "Oh Dr . I'm sorry for bringing it up."

Adora waves her off. "I mean it doesn't bother me. Not anymore at least. And I want you to know about it. You've been honest with me; I want to be honest with you." Adora offers, smiling at Catra. She

looks back out to the water, leaning back on her palms. "Things between Merms and I were easy. We were together for a year and a half just about. But it was never serious. She didn't care about her soulmate, I was terrified of finding mine and we just fit." She chances a look at Catra, finding her staring intently. Adora looks away again. "I loved her and she loved me. But the day she found Seahawk, she came home distraught saying her soulmate was an absolute idiot who almost set his own boat on fire—I could just tell. I mean, she'd never been more passionate about something."

Catra chuckles, shaking her head. "I'm not sure anger is passion for."

"That's true. But on Mermista they look very similar." Adora counters with a smile. She looks down at the sand. "She was adamant that we stay together. That what we had was good and Seahawk didn't have to ruin that. I believed that for about a day." Adora snorts. "Then we ran into him at the grocery store of all places. And the way they looked at each other just—I don't think I'd ever seen Mermista look at anyone or anything like that." She remembers the look clear as day in her mind's eye. "So, I grabbed her hand, and I said it had been great, but she needed to follow what she really wanted. And she kissed my cheek and walked up to him. That was that."

Adora lets her hands fall into her lap, wiping the sand on her knees. "Maybe I'm odd but it didn't hurt that much. I know Mermista is happier, and we're way better as friends. I knew Mermista wasn't going to be my life partner and I enjoyed the time we did share romantically." Adora keeps her eyes on the ocean, the waves are small, barely moving the water.

"So, you don't want something serious?" Adora senses something else lurking behind Catra's question.

"No, no. I just didn't want something serious with Mermista." Adora isn't afraid of commitment—she wants to love and be loved in return.

Catra hesitates, eyes boring into Adora. "What if it was us?" She finally whispers. The question hurts worse than anything has since her mark left her. She wants Catra but she refuses to torture herself with the idea of them for Catra's entertainment.

Adora turns to look at Catra, knees touching. "Cat, I don't think ~~no~~, I *know* it's not fair of you to ask that of me right now." Adora swallows the lump in her throat. "If you don't want me, that's okay, but that doesn't give you a right to look at my feelings for you under a telescope."

Catra places her hand on Adora's knee, tightly clutching her. "I know I don't have a right to the answer I do ~~I just wh~~at if I'm reconsidering going on the date? But I want to know what I'm risking our friendship for?" Catra is blushing now, eyes blown wide.

Adora considers her answer, eyes never leaving Catra's. "I think I would never be the same if we were together, Catra. Being with you would be life-changing. It would be like nothing I've done before."

Their friendship has already changed Adora from the ground up, it makes her feel more whole, more herself.

"I know that we have soulmates out there, supposedly perfect matches that are supposed to blow everything else out of the water." Adora honestly can't imagine anyone being a better match for her than Catra. She doesn't say that though. "I don't want to promise you that I won't ever leave because of a soulmate or anything else. Those assurances haven't done much for either of us in the past." Catra gives her a small smile. "But I promise you that right now, you are who I think about and if we were together, I would honor how I feel about you."

Catra's hand reaches out to Adora's sandy one, holding it tightly. Adora's looked at Catra's eyes dozens of times before, marveling at their shape and color, but they've never looked clearer than now. "Or, do you still want to go on that date?" She asks breathlessly.

Adora can feel her heart take flight in her chest. "You mean it?" She makes sure, she has to make sure. Adora can't get her hopes up for this if it isn't true.

"Yeah." She has a shy smile on her face.

She breathes in the salty ocean air and feels only elation. "Of course, Cat. I'd love nothing more." Adora beams at Catra grabbing her other hand so that they're now facing each other.

Catra leans in so close that Adora could count her individual lashes. She looks down at Adora's lips and then back at her eyes, leaning closer still. Close enough to kiss.

Adora places her finger on Catra's lips stopping her.

"No no, no, that'll jinx the date. You can have a kiss at the end of the night." The truth is, Adora doesn't think she could have one kiss and stop, and she doesn't want to get caught on the beach.

Catra gives her a salacious look and puckers her lips, kissing Adora's finger. Adora removes it like she's been burned. Catra smirks, her face still close. "You sure about that?" Her voice is low and teasing.

It takes every ounce of Adora's willpower to not kiss Catra when she looks at Adora like that, a challenge clear in her eyes. "I'm sure."

Catra flops backward into the sand with a loud groan. "Ugh, fine you suck." Adora follows Catra's lead and lays next to her in the sand, pressing a wet kiss on Catra's cheek and nuzzling it after.

"You like me." Adora accuses, euphoric. Catra gives her a smile that warms Adora more than the sun beating on her back.

"I do." She holds Catra close, not even sure how her arms ended up tightly winding around her body.

"Hold onto that thought in the next few minutes." Adora grins wickedly.

"What?" Adora. In a moment, Adora gets up and foists Catra up over her shoulder, laughing when she feels her hands pounding on her back.

"Adora you are *not* going to get my hair wet!" Catra screeched, but she hardly sounded mad, laughing as she squirms in Adora's grip.

Adora walks them both right into the ocean, and drops Catra gently, mindful of her hair. She offers Catra one of her hair ties and Catra puts her hair up in a bun.

"Still like me?" Adora beams.

"Yeah, but you're on thin fucking ice." Her tone doesn't match her words. Catra drops a kiss on Adora's collarbone as revenge and Adora swears her brain breaks. She watches a giggling Catra swim away.

Chapter End Notes

If u saw the chapter count go up no you didn't! Don't mind me just readjusting the whole last half of this plot right here lol.

I'd love to know what y'all are thinking! Comments and kudos make me happy also feel free to follow me on Twitter @KesFlower1 and Tumblr @KesFlower.

Next week: Glitra Exes/Secrets Are the Enemy Chapter 3 should be going up!

Next time: Catra and Adora go on their first date :)

Chapter 7

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora is pacing up a storm in her house, and Glimmer's questions are growing unhelpful fast. "How are you feeling? You look like you might throw up. Are you going to have to cancel?" Glimmer looks increasingly concerned as she rolls out more questions.

"No canceling!" Adora barks out. "I'm just a wreck, what if I mess this up Glim?" She is so nervous about her date with Catra. Glimmer heard Adora rambling on the phone and, after twenty minutes where she worried Adora might grow blue from lack of oxygen, showed up at her house for emotional support.

"Adora you've been friends with Catra for like eight months." Glimmer points out. "If you didn't have chemistry and a good foundation for romance, one of you would put a stop to this." It's never a good sign when Glimmer is the voice of reason.

"But I like her so much! I've never felt this way before about anyone." Adora whispers as if someone else might overhear in her house. She'd wanted to go out with Catra for ages, but now that it's finally happening, she's worried she built it up too big in her head, or worse, that Catra will find her lacking somehow, and then she'll lose her friendship too.

"Aww, this is really cute." She coos. Adora stares back, unimpressed. Glimmer puts a hand on her shoulder. "Look I've seen you two together. You look at Catra like she hung the moon and the stars. She looks back the same way. You just have to be yourself." Glimmer sounds confident.

Adora isn't so sure. "Would it be bad if I took at my first date flashcards?" She likes to be prepared.

Glimmer shoots the idea down in seconds. "Adora, those are *cursed*. I can't believe you made them at all. Besides, you already know all those things about Catra, you don't need an icebreaker."

Adora supposes she probably does know those things about Catra. Shit. "Okay, I can do this." She lets out a long breath. They've been hanging out for months now and there's no reason for their date to go poorly. Adora just needs to relax

The doorbell rings~~it~~ must be Catra, Adora stares at Glimmer, panic all over her face. Glimmer shoos her to open the door. Adora takes a deep breath, puts a smile on her face, and opens the door.

Catra is smiling back until she registers the look on Adora's face. "Or you are freaking me out." She states plainly. "Why are you smiling like that?" Catra sounds as concerned as Glimmer did a few moments ago.

"Nothing! This is just how I smile!" She says rather unconvincingly.

Catra snorts before rolling her eyes. "I mean, sure if you want to make a baby cry." Catra reaches her hand out to Adora and holds her hand. It's warm and fits perfectly in hers.

Adora deflates, shoulders coming down to a more normal level. "I just~~l'm~~ nervous. I want this to go well." She admits. She wants it more than anything she's wanted in a long time, but she doesn't say that aloud.

"Is there any reason why it wouldn't?" Catra asks, brow furrowed. She crosses her arms looking at Adora expectantly.

"Maybe you'll decide that you hate me?" Adora offers, only half joking.

Catra looks Adora up and down like she's considering it. "Nah. I've decided I like you." She says flippantly. Catra drops the act and gives

Adora a smile. "It's just me Dr . You don't have to impress me." Adora can't help but feel like all she wants is to impress Catra.

"That's what I said!"

Catra lets out a squeak in surprise. "Glimmer!" She looks past Adora to see Glimmer grabbing her purse.

"Y eah, sorry, I came to make sure Adora didn't die of anxiety and actually made it to the date. Ill be leaving, you crazy kids have fun now!" Glimmer hustles her way out the door , closing it behind her.

"Y ou ready to go? Heh." Adora says awkwardly .

Catra laughs. "Y eah, blondie let's go." They get into Catra's car and drive off, only moving for a few minutes until they park at the Crimson Waste. Adora looks at Catra, confused. She notices Catra's hand tighten on the steering wheel. "So, I thought a lot about this, and I know it's where I work, but it's also where we met, and they have this really cool band I think you would like"—

Adora grabs Catra's hand, making her fall silent. She suddenly realizes that Catra is nervous too. W eirdly that makes her feel better. "Cat. As long as I get to spend time with you, I don't care where we go. Thank you for planning this." Adora then drops a soft kiss onto Catra's hand.

Catra's blushing, her smile soft, and it makes Adora feel like she finally said the right thing. Once they get out of the car, Catra laces their fingers together. They sit at one of the tables near the stage. A band of three people has just finished setting up.

"Hey all, we're the Star Siblings, I hope you like our next set!" The band starts playing an interesting mix of rock and blues that Adora can't help but tap her feet to.

Catra grins at her. "Let' s dance." She pulls Adora up, and she willingly follows.

"I have to warn you, that I am not coordinated at all, *and* I will step all over your toes."She says low so only Catra hears. Adora has never had a dance end well.

"C'mon, I saw you playing volleyball. Y ou are *plenty* coordinated." Catra teases.

"Sports are dif ferent because I have a goal,"Adora explains as she awkwardly shifts her legs from one side to another, head tilted as she tries to find the beat.

Catra's smile turns wicked. "Guess we are going to have to come up with a goal for you hmm?"Catra grabs Adora's belt loops and pulls her flush against her. "Just move with me."Catra whispers into the shell of her ear.

Adora is helpless to heed the command.

It's probably the best she' s ever danced. It's like she found the rhythm she was missing her whole life beneath Catra's touch. They didn't stop dancing until the set was over . Adora could feel drops of sweat on her lower back.

"I hope you don't mind that I ordered ahead."Adora looks at their table, which might just have one of each of the menu items that the bar is currently selling. Except for the nachos, obviously .

"I don't think we can eat all that,"Adora says skeptically as she eyes all the steaming dishes.

"Eh, leftovers."Catra counters easily . They both sit down and Adora is thinking strategically about what she wants to eat first when a large shadow blocks the dim light.

"Y eah, don't worry , Kitty here has an employee discount."A gruf f voice that could only belong to Huntara says. Adora has seen her from afar but had never interacted directly with the hulking bar

owner. Besides death glares whenever she's leaning too close to Catra over the bar top anyway.

"Huntara! You can't crash my date." Catra groans putting her head in her hands.

"I can do whatever I want in my bar." Huntara all but growls. She smirks. "Besides I wanted to meet the woman you absolutely won't shut up about." Catra glares fiercely at her boss. Huntara holds her stare then backs off, waving at Adora. "I'll leave you two love birds alone now. Have a nice night." Huntara turns back to the bar.

"You talk about me?" Adora teases. She really can't say much, she never shuts up about Catra, but she's usually unflappable. Right now she's red and shy, glaring at her own shoe.

"I'll quit and get a new job. That'll show her." Catra mumbles under her breath.

"I can't believe you like me. That is *so* embarrassing for you." Adora leans her chair so that they are right next to each other and she puts her hand around the back of Catra's chair.

Catra shoots her a playful glare, one hand resting on Adora's leg. "Okay, are you going to let that go and dance with me, or do you want me to take you home?" She holds out her hand. Adora takes it just as the next set starts up.

"I had a great time tonight." Adora is sitting in Catra's car, her feet hurt from dancing.

It was just as good as Adora thought it could be, even better. They didn't lose that easy familiarity that their friendship permitted them and the soft touches and looks felt like so much more. She didn't have to push back her feelings for Catra, they could live in her head and on her face with no consequences.

"Me too."She replies as she grabs Adora' s hand, lacing their fingers together as they pull up to her house.

She feels a pit of disappointment, thinking that it could be the end of their date. "Do you want to come to my house? W e can have a nightcap?"Adora suggests, hoping that Catra isn't too tired.

"Y eah, a *nightcap*? Y ou haven't even let me kiss you yet."Catra's tone is suggestive as she waggles her eyebrows.

Adora rolls her eyes. "I'm just not ready for the night to end."She admits softly, leaning closer to Catra.

Catra melts into the leather car seat. "How can you just say shit like that."She mutters, trying to hide the blush on her face. "Y eah blondie, let's have a nightcap."They walk into Adora's house with minimal fuss.

"Y ou can take a look around while I look for something for us to drink,"Adora says as she heads towards the kitchen, suddenly nervous. It's the first time she's been in her house alone with Catra.

"Y ou are going to regret giving me permission to snoop,"Catra says gleefully as she theatrically opens a random drawer.

"I don't have anything to hide, Cat,"Adora calls from the kitchen, laughing at Catra's antics.

Adora is rooting through her liquor cabinet looking for a fancy after dinner Micah and Angella gifted her last year when she hears Catra's voice calling for her . "Adora is that you?"She asks with amusement.

She gives up her search for the moment, and pokes her head out of the kitchen, noting that Catra is in the living room. She's standing by some of the pictures Adora has framed on her walls. Adora walks toward her and peers over Catra's shoulder to see what she is

looking at. She smiles at the picture of her with a baby Angel, just shy of his second birthday.

"Hmm, yeah me at the beach. That was Angel's first time. You should have seen how cute he was running about in the sand." She smiles at the memory, one of her favorites with Angel. It was always special when she got to see him experience something for the first time.

"Is that your soul mark?" She asks curiously, pointing to the abstract heart that looked tattooed onto Adora's left shoulder.

Adora nods. "Yeah, Cat. You'd never seen it before?" She racks her brain for a time when she actually showed Catra her soul mark and comes to a blank. She feels a little silly—of course, she'd probably never noticed, it's not like she had the mark when they met.

"No. I don't think you've seen mine either." She offers.

Adora thinks about it and realizes it's true. "Huh. That is a little odd."

Catra shrugs. "I mean, we both have our feelings on it, not that weird for our soul marks not to come up necessarily."

She scrolls through her phone and pulls up an older picture of her and Scorpia, handing it over to Adora. There on her left shoulder is her soul mark. It's a strange-looking M, it almost looks like a mask someone could wear, the color a vibrant red. She can't help but notice that the top of Catra's mark and hers are very similar.

Adora laughs at the coincidence. "So, we both have our marks on our left shoulder, and they are both in weird colors." She glances at Catra shyly. "Did you also get a ton of people telling you how lucky you were that your mark was so bold and visible?"

Catra groans. "Yes, all the time!" She shakes her head. "People really don't know how to mind their own business."

Adora smiles, taking a step closer to Catra. "I hear that." She runs her finger under the capped sleeve of her shirt, right where her soul mark might be. She tries to imagine what it would look like on Catra's skin. "You know, I looked for my soul mark on your shoulder the night we met," Adora confesses. "I felt so dumb at the time, but I think it's because some part of me knew you were going to have a special place in my life."

It's stupid and sappy~~p~~erhaps too emotionally charged to admit after a first date~~b~~ut she's done with holding back how she feels about this woman who changed everything for her.

Catra stutters a laugh. "You cannot possibly say something that romantic and not kiss me." She looks at Adora with hooded eyes.

"Kiss me then." Adora challenges, ducking her head a little. Catra gently holds Adora's jaw and closes the distance between them.

Adora has never felt so moved by a simple kiss. It tastes like beer and salt and something else that's uniquely Catra. It feels like she was always meant to do this with Catra, any former kiss is a facsimile of the real thing. Adora sighs into the kiss.

Catra's hands wrap around her shoulders, tugging Adora a little lower. The blonde complies, tugging Catra toward the couch so they can both sit. Catra clambers onto her lap, using the new height advantage to deepen the kiss. Adora breaks the kiss and trails kisses down her neck. She places a kiss on Catra's shoulder, and it feels like her skin crackles under Adora's touch.

Catra's eyes darken, and her breath goes ragged. "Adora, I'm not leaving your house tonight," Catra says as she wraps her arms around Adora's neck. Adora quickly nods and pulls Catra up by her thighs, encouraging her to wrap her legs around her as she stands up.

"You aren't going anywhere." Adora agrees as she kisses Catra's jaw. She was going to kiss every inch of Catra she could reach and

then some. There’s no reason they can’t belong to each other.

Chapter End Notes

Okay so, I need you all to TRUST THE PROCESS. And maybe don’t hate me yet? I think this isn’t a twist many people are expecting so I’m excited (and a little nervous NGL) about how you all react. Let me know!

Comments = Kudos = Happy Res. Follow me on Twitter @ResFLower1 and Tumblr @ResFlower.

Chapter 8

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"So, when are you coming over with your *girlf riend*?" Glimmer wiggles her eyebrow, using an annoying singing tone when her voice wraps around the last word. She's taken it upon herself to be insufferable now that Catra and Adora have finally made things official.

Still, Adora grins as she cuts into her chicken. "It's been almost two months Glim, you can stop saying girlfriend like you believe in cooties."

Glimmer rolls her eyes as she takes a sip of water, her glass making a small thunk noise when she sets it down on the table. "And you could stop looking like a dope every time I bring up that you have a girlfriend, yet here we are."

Adora sighs, not bothering to try to deny it. "She's so amazing, Glim. I can't believe she's mine sometimes." She puts her elbow on the table and rests her head on her closed fist.

She's the happiest she's ever been in a relationship. Adora always thought she and Catra would make a good match~~she~~ she wouldn't have wanted to risk their friendship if she didn't think that~~but~~ but she's still surprised by how naturally they fit together.

Glimmer looks like she's watching a viral puppy video but she's really just staring at Adora. "This is just too cute! I've never seen you this way over a girl."

"I never have been. Besides at this point, I feel like Catra might steal my title of best friend. You two almost hang out more than you and I

do."Glimmer and Catra have been fast friends, taking to grabbing lunch often. "She's not just some girl,"Adora adds.

"Never , you are stuck with me for life."Glimmer swears with a flash of her teeth. "But Im just so happy for you. After your thirtieth birthday I was worried. Im glad that you found what you wanted."

Adora surveys the half-empty restaurant for a moment. "Thanks, Glim."She gives her best friend a look. "Y ou know, you can say after my mark disappeared. It isnt like I dont know what you're trying to say."She points out.

"I know , but I wasnt trying to bring that up."She insists, a rare blush coming to her cheeks.

Adora grabs one of the sugar packets on the table to fiddle with. "What? Soulmates"?

"Y eah."

Something about the way Glimmer looks down at the table makes Adora feel unsettled. "Do you think Im wrong to be with Catra with a soulmate out there somewhere"?

"No, not at all!"She crosses her arms. "The opposite really . You were always insistent that you didnt need to search for your soulmate, and you know how I felt about that choice. But Im happy to see you happy Adora."

Adora rolls her eyes. "Everyone keeps saying stuf f like that."All her friends have been beyond supportive, to the point where it feels a little too much at times.

"Because you're practically vibrating with joy , Adora. It's kind of hard not to tell you have your girl now."

She knows she must look dopey, but she cant help the way she smiles when she hears Glimmer refer to Catra as hers. "I really like

her, and I think she feels the same."Adora doubts that this type of emotion could be one-sided. "And I just want to follow where it takes us."

"Ugh, young love. Disgusting."Glimmer makes a face but smiles anyway. "Do you want to pick Angel up with me from my mom's or do you have your own shit to do?"

Adora puts down her cutlery. "I've got some errands to run but Catra and I can come over for dinner this week."

"Sounds like a plan."

She knows Catra can see how fast she's walking once she walks into the bar, but she doesn't really care. "Hi."She breathes out when she's in front of her girlfriend.

Catra rolls her eyes. "Hey , loser."But her smile is soft as she reaches out and tugs her close so she can press a quick kiss to her cheek from over the bar. "I missed you."

"Me too."She sits down, not bothering to look at the menu. At this point, she knows it by heart. "Is that weird coconut shrimp thing still available?"It's been on the rotating menu but Adora has never actually seen it.

"You are not ordering that."She says, eyeing Adora wearily . "Try again."

She laughs and shakes her head. "I'm a paying customer ."

"You're also my girlfriend and I'm trying to take care of you. That shit is awful, please pick something different."She all but begs.

"Oh, Cat you want to take care of me?"She teases, knowing that although embarrassed, Catra is fiercely protective of her. She leans forward on the bar top before remembering the owner. "Have you

told Huntara that we're dating? I'm kind of worried she'll deck me either way."

"She knows. Had some choice word about it." Catra puffs herself up as if that'll make her impression of Huntara better. "It's about time kitty, you only stared at each other in my bar for months."

Adora laughs. "Well, she's not exactly wrong on that front."

"Oh yeah, blondie? You in a rush?"

She shakes her head. "No baby, not at all." She loves the way that Catra blushes at the nickname, averting her gaze for a moment before looking back. "We found each other at the right time." She knows she sounds like a lovesick sap because it's what she is.

Catra rolls her eyes, but she doesn't fool Adora. She looks pleased as she grabs one of the beer glasses and fills it with something from the tap. "Try it."

"What is it?" The liquid looks darker than the beers Catra typically has her try. It makes Adora nervous.

"Have a taste and you'll find out." Catra challenges as she pours another beer.

Adora leers at her. "There's definitely *something* I'd like to have a taste of here."

She shoves Adora's shoulder. "Don't be so crass. Drink up."

Adora sniffs the glass and takes a careful sip, surprised by how light and fruity it is. "I've never had a beer like this." She comments before trying it again.

"That's because it's not a beer~~, it's~~ mead."

"Oh! Interesting." She likes it a lot~~, it~~ kind of reminds her of cider, which she supposes makes sense. "When did you get it in?"

"Got in just yesterday , loaded it in the tap today." She says proudly . She'd recently been promoted to assistant manager which meant she had more responsibilities regarding the logistics of shipments to the bar and staff scheduling.

"I didn't even know you had mead here."

"We didn't--this is the first batch." The way that Catra looks away when she says it gives Adora an idea.

"Catra... did you talk to Huntara about trying out a mead option?"

Adora had mentioned idly that she thought it would be cool if more bars had beer alternatives like ciders or mead and that she'd never tried mead before.

"No! Definitely not." Catra denies it, face red.

"You know all our friends say I have it bad, but they just don't know how much of a softy you are."

"And it stays that way , Grey." She threatens.

"Yes ma'am, whatever you want." She grins. "How long do you have?" The bar is mostly empty , only two other people are sitting at the far end of the bar.

"Another hour , at least."

"Want to stay with me tonight?" Adora holds her breath a little. Despite kind of jumping into the relationship since they went on their first date, Catra had only stayed over a few times.

"Yeah. I can meet you there." Catra suggests as she pushes a brown lock behind her ear.

Adora frowns a little at that. "I can wait until you close out if you want." If she goes home now she'll probably just clean her house until Catra gets there anyway.

Catra shakes her head. "I don't want to keep you waiting."

"It's not that bad." She smiles. "Besides, I'd rather be here with you."

"I'll close up if you two stop being this sickly sweet in front of me," Huntara replies, grabbing the cleaning rag out of Catra's hand.

Catra tries to snatch it back but the bar owner holds the rag above her head. "But I have an hour left"—

"Kitty . Does it look like anyone is here on a W ednesday except your girl?" The bar is well and truly empty now , but that doesn't usually affect the closing time. "Get out of here before I change my mind." Somehow, Huntara makes the favor sound like a threat.

Catra hesitates for a moment until Huntara gives her a quick shove. "I'll see you Friday ." She adds.

"Alright, boss." Catra acquiesce, coming out from behind the bar .

They walk together to the parking lot hand in hand.

"Do you think that was alright?" Adora worries. She's happy to have more time with Catra, but she doesn't want to af fect her work.

She waves the hand that isn't being held by Adora. "Y eah, I'll talk with her on Friday but she's probably fine. I've seen her let other employees off early so I'm not overly concerned."

"Okay ." Adora stops as they get to Catra' s car. "See you in a minute?" She reminds, in case Catra forgot.

"W ait." Catra leans up and pulls Adora in for a long kiss, one that makes her gasp and lean closer. She feels Catra pull away, but she chases after her, placing another kiss on her lips. When she opens her eyes, Catra is looking at her with amusement. "Okay , now we can go."

She watches Catra walk toward her car door and can almost feel her self-satisfaction at catching Adora flat-footed.

"Just wait until we get home!" Adora can't help but yell after her.

She stops and sends Adora a look over her shoulder that could only be described as a challenge. "I'm looking forward to it princess."

Adora practically jogs to her car.

"So, you didn't like the play?" Catra ribs as she bumps into Adora's shoulder.

She rolls her eyes, wrapping her hand around her girlfriend. "I liked it! I just thought the end was dumb." Adora shakes her head. "She goes looking for her soulmate on a worldwide trip and then finds her at home? Seems unlikely."

"Well, I think the point is that you meet the right person at the right time, not on your own time," Perfuma explains. She and Scorpia share a lovestruck look.

Adora wants to press and ask how that jives with the soulmate finding apps that Perfuma and Scorpia themselves used to connect but she decides against it. She's generally had a great time on the double date. She doesn't want to spoil it with a disagreement. They continue to walk in relative silence.

"Hey, do you want to get coffee and dessert in that new place around the corner?" Scorpia suggests to the group.

Adora looks down at Catra. It's a hip little vegan shop that has a nice ambiance and plenty of interesting selection, but she's not sure if Catra is done for the night. Her girlfriend shrugs one shoulder and raises an eyebrow as if to say she doesn't mind either way, but Adora catches the way her eyes dart down the road that would take them to the shop.

"Yeah, that sounds good," Adora says. "What do you think, Cat?"

She rolls her eyes to hide a smile. "Alright, we can go."

The walk is a short one and Adora pulls the door open for the other women, Catra and Perfuma walking in first. Scorpia hesitates and looks up at Adora then gestures for her to close the door.

Adora furrows her brow but does as she's told. Perfuma and Catra kept walking—it would probably take a moment for them to realize that the other two stayed behind.

"What's up?" Adora asks with a furrowed brow.

"I want to talk to you for a second." Scorpia looks more serious than Adora has ever seen her. "Catra has been through a lot, and I need to know that you aren't planning on breaking her heart."

Her eyes dart to the door, mindful that Perfuma and Catra could come looking for them. "Scorpia. I can't promise I'll never hurt her, but that's never my intention." She puts her palms together, squeezing tightly. "I—I love Catra. I want to be with her forever."

She hasn't said as much to the brunette, but she knows it in her heart. Being with Catra is right for her and she just hopes she can be enough for Catra too.

Scorpia immediately lights up. "Aww! Does Wildcat know?"

Adora shakes her head. "If you could keep it between us?" She wants to tell Catra, but she doesn't want to take a chance of scaring her off. Adora's waiting for the right moment to come along for her to be able to speak of her feelings.

"Of course! My lips are sealed." Scorpia gestures like she's zipping her lips and locking them.

Adora eyes the other woman for a moment. "Okay, cool. Can we go in now?"

"Oh! Yeah! Right, right." Scorpia nods sheepishly, opening the door for Adora.

They find that Catra and Perfuma are already sitting in a booth. "What happened? Did you two find something interesting outside?" Catra asks, eyes darting between Scorpia and Adora.

"Scorpia just had to tie her shoes," Adora says, knowing the lie is obvious and terrible, but not quite caring.

"Yeah! My shoelace got untied and Adora pointed it out." Scorpia nods vigorously, eyes wide like a kindergartener trying to steal candy.

Catra and Perfuma share a knowing look and then both nod, not asking any other questions. "Let's get some dessert then." Perfuma offers.

Both women sit next to their girlfriends and start looking at the menu.

"Ma." Adora greets. "How are you?" She felt a twinge of guilt—it had been a month since she'd called her mother, and she'd promised herself she would be better about it.

"As expected." Hope shoots off her typical response. "How is Catra?"

"She's good we are going on a date tomorrow." Saturday mornings end up working out as the best date time between Adora's nine to five and Catra's work at the bar.

Hope hums. "That sounds nice. Are you happy?"

"Yeah. I really am."

"Good. You seem it."

Adora bites her lip. "How are you, really?"

Hope sighs. "As good as I can be, Adora. Not much else to say. Razz needed help with her television, so we've been trying to puzzle that out." She lets out a dry chuckle.

"I can drive up and take a look if you want?" Hope is terrible at technology and Adora can only imagine how bad Razz is.

"No, we can do it." Something about the way she says it makes Adora realize it isn't about making the TV work again at all.

"Alright. Let me know if you do end up needing something." She offers anyway.

"I will." She pauses in a way that makes Adora sit up straighter. "Adora... make sure you invest in your happiness. No one can do that except for you."

The echoes of longing in Hope's voice puts Adora in a tailspin. "You want to talk about something?" She probes.

"No, I'm just glad you've found Catra. She's good for you."

Adora had been surprised by how well Hope had taken to Catra—she hadn't really bothered getting to know Mermista. She thinks that in the five months she's been dating Catra they've interacted more than Hope interacted with Mermista the whole time they were together.

"Anything specific that makes you say that?" Adora presses again. It's not frequent that Hope is open to talking about matters of the heart.

"You're different." She says simply. "Less afraid. Happier."

"It's been amazing." Adora sighs. She worries her lip again. "If you could be with mom again, what do you think you would have done differently?"

She rarely asks about Mara, always afraid of setting Hope off but maybe that's been Adora's problem all along.

"I don't know that I'd do anything dif ferently."Hope sighs. "I'd love her just the same, but I'd enjoy it more. Slow down time and sit in it. You'll understand."

Adora isn't sure if she does, but she nods to herself, taking the words to heart. "Okay . Is anything else going on in the high school?"

Hope starts telling a story about how one of the other teachers might retire soon, and the conversation ends on a lighter note.

"Cat-ah!"Angel yells ex citedly before sprinting and bulldoz ing into Catra.

She grunts softly on impact, putting both her hands on his shoulders. "Hey , Angel."She says softly , ruffling his hair, the curls bouncing back to place.

"Up."He says defiantly , hands stretched to the sky.

Catra makes an ex aggerated grunt as she lifts the toddler , placing him on her hip. She nods politely as Angel launches into a story, using his little hands to point and talk. She looks so at home here~~a~~ place filled with Adora's found family . She wonders if Catra feels like Bright Moon is home now and if maybe Adora has in some way added to that.

"Y ou look like you want to put a baby in her."

Adora startles and she turns to her friend that seemed to come out of nowhere. "~~G~~limmer!"Adora can feel her cheeks warm and as she covers them with her hands. "I do not!"

"Y es, you do."She insists. "I'd recogniz e that anywhere~~it's~~ how we got Angel."

Adora grimaces making a disgusted noise in the back of her throat. "First of f, ew." She did not need to think about Bow and Glimmer like that. Ever. "Second, there's no baby talk. Not now—maybe not ever . I don't even know if I want a baby ."

"Baby"?

She looks down horrified at Angel's big eyes. He must have wandered over when she wasn't paying attention. Suddenly , he has a big gap-tooth grin. "DORA BABY!" He shrieks, pointing at Adora's midsection.

"No no, Angel!" She whispers trying to grab him but missing. "No baby!"

"Baby , baby!" He disagrees as he runs and starts shouting around the house.

Adora groans loudly glaring at Glimmer. "Y ou put him up to this." She accuses.

"Oh, I didn't but if I could have I would." She laughs and Adora thinks she's never been this red in her life.

"Why is Angel yelling about a Dora baby"? Catra sounds amused, if a little confused, as she walks closer.

Adora was wrong. *Now* she's redder than she's ever been her whole life.

"Oh, he's just wondering about a little cousin." Glimmer says nonchalantly.

"A cousin"? Catra's voice climbs an octave.

Adora wants to look at her but instead keeps her eyes firmly on the tile. "I have no input for this discussion and I'm disowning Glimmer ." She says resolutely.

"Adora you can't disown me! Besides you're the one that looks like you turned into a firetruck." Glimmer pauses. "Although you're not the only one."

Adora finally looks up and finds that Catra is as red as she is, although it's harder to see under her tan.

"Shut up, Glimmer ," Catra says crossly . She reaches out and takes Adora's hand. "I like your kid better than you, anyway ."

Glimmer sputters and watches as Adora and Catra head out to the patio where Bow is watching Angel yell about babies.

He raises an eyebrow at them. "Do I even want to know?"

"You really don't," Adora assures him before taking a seat on the outdoor couch, pulling Catra with her.

Bow moves to stand next to them. "Can I get you a beer? Wine? Shots?"

Adora thinks about it. "I'll take a beer ."

"Me too," Catra adds.

"Coming right up. Make sure my child doesn't die." He glances at where Angel found one of his toy trucks and is rolling it around the yard, thoughts of babies forgotten.

"Yeah, we'll keep an eye out," Adora promises.

Bow claps and gives them a thumbs up, hoping into the kitchen for refreshments.

"I'm sorry Glimmer was being weird," Adora says, not knowing what else to say about that unfortunate interaction.

"It's fine, I'm sure she was just messing around."

Adora put her arm around Catra, loving how her girlfriend leaned her head into her shoulder. She drops her head onto Catra's, a small sigh rolling through her.

"I'm not trying to like, wife you up and have a billion babies right now," Adora explains, feeling like she has to say something more to Catra. "I really love how things are with us." She bites her lip, wincing at her use of love in this context—especially since she and Catra hadn't exchanged any declarations of that kind.

She can feel Catra nod against her shoulder. "I love how things are right now too. I want to enjoy it." She says finally.

She places a soft kiss on her head. "Good. I'm glad we're on the same page."

The rest of the evening with the Moon-Archer family runs by in a blur until they end up back at Adora's place curled up on a couch watching a movie.

Adora runs her thumb over Catra's hip bone, and she doesn't want to move for the rest of the night. "Why don't you stay?" Adora whispers on Catra's skin, followed by a soft kiss.

Catra groans, a disappointed noise. "I need to go feed Melog." She reminds her.

Adora feels a little putout, but she understands. "I can go stay with you?" She suggests instead.

Catra turns, placing a soft kiss to Adora's lips. "Yeah. That works princess." She grunts as she gets up and pulls Adora up with her.

As Adora packs up her overnight back she can feel her blood racing and her happiness at knowing the rest of the night is just her and Catra, curled together and then waking on each other's arms.

She watches Catra peek her head into her room. "You coming or what?" She asks with a smile.

"I'm going."

Later that month, they have one of those dates that you see in the movies—candlelight dinner with a walk by a small lake, finishing in Catra's apartment. It's one of the few night dates they've been able to coordinate. Except instead of a kiss goodnight, Adora gets to go inside and be with her when it's all over.

Catra tugs her in through the door, a warm smile on her face as they make it past the living room, a sleeping Melog curled on a couch, and into Catra's bedroom.

They don't stay together every night but it's an odd week when they don't sleep over at least a few times. Adora doesn't have a drawer but it's a close thing, more than half her hoodies have found themselves in Catra's closet.

The low light of the bedroom highlights Catra's silhouette in the black dress she wore tonight. The material drapes around her chest, dipping low so her whole sternum is exposed. The whole night, Adora had trouble keeping her eyes on Catra's face, and from the smirks Catra sent her way, she knew it.

Now there's no reason for Adora not to stare. "Your eyes look like they might fall out of your head." Catra sounds plenty pleased with herself as she steps closer, her own eyes roaming Adora.

"Well can you blame me?" She pulls Catra close twirling her in a slow circle. "You look gorgeous."

She laughs, pressing her back to Adora's front. "You do too."

Adora presses a soft kiss on her neck. "Ready for bed?" She asks softly.

Catra tugs on her shoulder straps and steps out of her dress, leaving her in barely anything at all. Adora swallows as Catra makes her way to the bed, glancing at Adora over her shoulder. "Ready?" She teases.

Adora quickly strips out of her own dress and crawls into the bed after Catra. When they are both under the covers she leans in and kisses Catra.

The kisses are long and slow like they have all the time in the world to be together. Their skin presses together and Adora groans, loving the way she can feel Catra from their tangled legs to their pressed foreheads. She keeps kissing her, the butterflies in her stomach rioting at the feeling of Catra's smile on her lips.

She pulls back a little and she's breathless again, this time not from their kisses. Catra is so beautiful, soft and open as she lays under Adora, one hand tangled in her hand and the other under her jaw, her fingers grazing sensitive skin there.

Catra pulls her in, the way the moon pulls the sea from hundreds of miles away. "Catra, I love you." The words slip out and Adora is honestly surprised she was able to keep them in for as long as she did. The six months they've been dating have been amazing and she doesn't want anything else in a partner.

Catra drops the hand that's in her hair, studying her face. A slow smile crosses her face, eyes getting a little smaller from it. "You mean that?"

She nods. "It feels like I've been in love with you for the longest time."

She could swear that it happened the moment Adora laid eyes on Catra, but she knows that's a bit of an exaggeration. Still, it feels like this choice ~~to~~ know and later to love Catra ~~ha~~ had been building inside of her.

Catra looks at her with wonder, leaning up and placing a soft kiss on her cheek. "I love you too."

Adora lets out a laugh, unable to contain her joy. "Really?"

Another kiss. "Yes, dummy. Really."

"I can stay the night?" She asks softly. She just wants Catra to stay with her always.

"I'd like to see you try to go." Catra cracks placing a soft kiss on her collarbone.

"Never." She swears, nuzzling her girlfriend.

When she opens her eyes, Catra is smiling at her, her own split eyes dancing with love and light.

Adora smiles back. She thinks she gets it now, what Hope meant about slowing time.

Chapter End Notes

I just love them they love each other so manyyyy. I think this is the softest chapter I've ever written for a multi-chapter fic. Thank you all so much for reading!

As always, kudos and comments are most welcome and encouraged! Twitter is @FemesFlower1 and Tumblr is @FemesFlower.

Next Week: We have Battle Cry chapter 4!

Chapter 9

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

When Adora stretches in the morning, she lets out a soft hiss at the feeling in her legs. Adora is sore, which she finds a little hard to believe. Sure she'd moved boxes, but it wasn't anything crazy— Catra didn't have much in the way of furniture.

She turns on her side and finds Catra sleeping, her face fully relaxed and her breaths deep. Adora props her head up and smiles as she stares at her girlfriend. Now that they've moved in together officially, nothing would get in the way of this.

Catra turns, eyes still closed but she's facing Adora, her hands under her cheek. Her cheek is pressed into them and Adora just knows she'll have a mark when she finally wakes up.

She leans forward, placing a soft kiss on Catra's forehead. Her girlfriend doesn't notice, staying asleep. She basks in the morning for at least ten more minutes before Catra starts to wake.

Her eyes close shut tightly before she cracks one open. "Hey Adora."She murmurs sleepily , a smile in her voice. "How long have you been up?"

"Not long."She assures softly , enjoying how Catra's eyes slowly open, lashes fluttering as she adjusts to the light.

Catra takes in her lovestruck expression and immediately sticks her tongue out. "You're so gross."She complains as she burrows her head into her pillow.

"You're so warm and cute."Adora returns. She pulls Catra close,

placing soft kisses on her neck.

Catra stretches her legs, one of them on top of Adora's. "You're such a sap."

"Well I'm your sap. And this is our bed now. Officially." She reminds her girlfriend, giddy about it.

"Adora I can't even remember the last time we didn't sleep in the same bed."

"Sure but this is *our* bed Catra." She runs one hand down the side of her hip, tracing her fingers down her quad. "It's our home." Adora had been patient and waited after their anniversary to ask Catra to move in and it had been well worth the wait.

"You're my home." Catra says instinctively. Adora expects her to balk a little at her admission but instead her eyes are serious as she stares. "You're my home." She says it again, this time cupping Adora's cheeks.

"You can't say something that romantic and not kiss me." Adora says softly, tossing back Catra's words from their first date.

She rolls her eyes but leans in, placing a soft kiss on her lips. "Happy now?" She doesn't go far, her lips almost grazing Adora's when she speaks.

"I'm always happy with you." Adora replies. She smiles at the brunette. "But I can stand to get a few more kisses."

Catra grins and rolls on top of Adora, placing loud smacking kisses along her cheek and forehead. "Those enough, princess?" She asks, humor dancing in her eyes.

Just to be contrarian, Adora shakes her head no, laughing when Catra deploys another barrage of kisses. "Okay, okay, that's good."

She says through her laugh.

She turns her head and captures Catra's lips in a sweet kiss. "I love you."Adora reminds softly .

Just like every other time that Adora tells her girlfriend she loves her , Catra melts in her arm~~s~~now she looks lovestruck instead of Adora.

"I love you too, Adora."

The moment is burst when they hear a demanding meow. Both women look as Melog hops on top of them, kneading and yowling.

"Looks like someone is hungry ."Adora observes as the disgruntled cat walks all over them.

Catra laughs. "I'll say ."She gives Adora a quick kiss. "I'll feed the little monster and Ill be back."

Adora watches Catra walk away with a slight smile on her face. She doesn't think her life has ever been this perfect.

Adora has taken to doing the groceries since they moved in together ~~sh~~e finds that although Catra is fantastic at keeping on top of a lot of chores like the laundry and dishes, groceries seem harder. She doesn't mind, finding it entertaining to walk down the aisles and put together the items they need.

She's contemplating whether the price dif ference merits buying chicken thighs over chicken breasts when someone catches her eye. Almost at the exact moment Adora's eyes hit the woman's frame, she's staring back.

When Adora sees her, her arm burns in the way it never had in her whole life. It's like there's a hot poker jabbed in it, that heats her from the inside out. She lets out a yelp of surprise, her hand going to her

shoulder. She watches the woman mirror her, the same mix of shock and pain crossing her face.

The woman seems to be clued into what is happening before Adora, walking straight up to her with excitement on her face. Adora is still trying to wrap her mind around the intense pain that faded as if it never happened.

"It's you isn't it?" She says the moment she reaches Adora. The excited energy is kind of contagious and Adora can't help but smile at her.

"Sorry , I don't understand..." Adora lingers, hoping to get a name.

"Juliet." She informs. Juliet is taller than Adora and hard to look away from. She's pretty , sure, but it's more than that. Something about the way she holds herself has Adora keep rattling something in her brain, almost like she recognizes her from somewhere.

"Adora." She of fers in turn. "What are you talking about?" She asks.

Then Juliet rolls up her sleeve, and there's Adora's mark. She'd almost forgotten what her mark looked like, only seeing it in odd pictures now.

"That's my mark." Adora says dumbly . She leans in closer and looks with a furrowed brow. "But...it's not a mark?"

The colors are flat and not quiet as vibrant as Adora recalls. Her mark almost glowed blue but this looked dulled.

Juliet rolls her sleeve back down. "T attoo." She explains. "I thought, once I lost my mark, it would be the easiest way to find my soulmate if I ever ran into them. And now here you are."

Soulmate. This woman is *her soulmate*. She'd never expected to find her and she's right in front of Adora, which is terrible because--

"I have a girlfriend."She blurts out. The whole encounter has been so unexpected and jarring that Adora hadn't thought about the implications of what she was seeing with her own eyes until that moment.

"Okay ."Juliet gives her an uncertain smile.

Her uncertainty tugs at Adora's gut. "Sorry that's weird. I just—I never really counted on finding you."She expects to feel a spike of fear. This is her soulmate standing in front of her.

Instead, she just feels this unexplainable connection, like she's known Juliet even though they've only spoken a few words. It's the closest she's felt to someone from just seeing them.

She shakes her head a little, trying to have a coherent thought.

Juliet seems to be on the same wavelength. "I didn't think I'd find you either."The confession feels more intimate than anything said in a grocery store has a right to be. "How about I give you my number and we can talk whenever you're ready?"

Adora nods, grateful. "Okay ."They exchange numbers and then stand awkwardly in front of the dairy aisle.

Juliette claps a hand on the shoulder where Adora's mark should have been. "I'm really glad to meet you Adora."

"Me too."Adora finds herself surprised that she means it. Something in her feels shifted in a way she never understood before this moment.

"Well, I just moved into town so I'll be around."Juliet adds. With a friendly wave, she walks away and Adora is left staring at Catra's favorite cereal in her cart a sense of dread creeping over her.

It takes another thirty minutes for Adora to put herself together enough to walk into their apartment. She puts down the groceries on the countertop, her arms straining from carrying all the bags at once.

"Catra?" She calls out, part of her hoping that maybe Catra went on a walk or something. Adora still isn't sure what she should say or how she should say it, but she knows every moment she keeps this to herself she's betraying Catra's trust in her .

"Hey Adora."

Her girlfriend walks up to her, wrapping her arms around her necks and pressing up for a sweet kiss. It's short and fast--like individually , each kiss didn't matter as much because there are endless possibilities to kiss each other.

Adora holds on to that feeling as she looks down at Catra. Something must show on her face because Catra reaches up and cups her cheek, her head tilted as she looks at Adora.

"Are you alright? Y ou look like you've seen a ghost."

Adora almost wants to laugh at that. It's true in a way--given how she's always felt about soulmates. Once she settled down, seeing Juliet felt like all her insecurities and fears greeting her in a grocery store.

"Catra I need to tell you something. Please don't freak out." She whispers the last words her gut clenching with anxiety . She doesn't want to hurt Catra but this isn't something she can hide from her .

Catra's eyes dart between Adora's searching her face for a clue as to what comes next. "Adora, you're scaring me."

She breathes deep, keeping her eyes on Catra as she reaches up to grab that hand that was touching her face. "I met my soulmate today." She finally gets the words past the lump on her throat.

The difference is immediate. Catra drops her hand as if she'd been burned, stepping back. Adora holds onto the hand not letting her run away.

"It's happening again." Catra says almost absentmindedly , eyes already filled with fear.

Adora fills with panic, clutching Catra's hand tighter . "No no Cat listen~~I don't~~ ~~I didn't~~ decide to do anything." She presses.

"But you will." Catra says it with certainty then a sob breaks out of her. It's the sound of a human being split open from the inside and it rings in Adora's ears.

Adora reaches out to wrap her arms around Catra, but she pulls back further and now they aren't touching. Adora feels stupid, her hand hanging useless in the air. Of course Catra doesn't want her touch, she's the one that's hurting her right now .

"Catra, I love you." Adora's crying now too, her breathing jagged as she tries to reach Catra. "I don't want this to change things."

Her heart aches in her chest, ripping itself into pieces. It's not fair— she never asked for this to happen to her and now she put that look on Catra's face.

Catra laughs sharply but it's choked out by her tears. "Adora, this changes everything."

"It doesn't have to." She tries reaching out again and Catra lets her hold one of her hands. "W e moved in together and we've been happy." Maybe it's as simple as that.

Catra shakes her head. "Y eah but that's before you met whoever it is that the universe decided was for you." Her voice is bitter and angry . Adora can't blame her .

She lets go of Adora's hand again and turns, heading to their bedroom. "Catra." She walks after her, feeling like she losing the opportunity to fix this but she still has no idea how.

Catra stops in front of their closet, grabbing a bag and stuffing clothes into it blindly.

Adora's heart drops into her toes. "Catra what are you doing?" The words are panicked and unsure even though it's clear as day what's happening.

Catra looks up at her and Adora feels her heart crumble again at the look on her face. "I need space I just—I need some time. Figure out what you want." The last words are sharp and prickly, an order and a demand rolled in one.

Adora bites her lip. She wants to tell Catra that she knows. That it's obviously her. The love she feels for Catra isn't something she'd abandon after a first meeting with someone, soul mark or no.

But she knows that isn't what Catra wants to hear, a knee-jerk reaction to try and get her to stay. So Adora swallows the words and promises and instead nods.

"I'll call you after you've had some time." Adora finally says, biting her lip to try to stop her crying. Her eyes already feel gross and she can't breathe through her nose right.

She walks Catra to the door, feeling like she's completely lost control of the situation. Before Catra walks out the door, she grabs her hand bring it up to her lips for a soft kiss.

"I love you." She reminds Catra fiercely, wanting her to know that hasn't changed. "And I'm sorry."

Catra shakes her head, she can barely look at Adora. "You didn't do

anything wrong."The words sound resigned and defeated. She says them to the vinyl floor. "I'll see you later ."Her eyes are vacant as she tugs on the door handle.

With that quiet assurance, Catra walks out of their new apartment leaving only doubts and hurts in her wake.

Chapter End Notes

So that happened 😬

Im curious if anyone saw this coming and your thoughts on the matter. I feel like it might feel unexpected to some, but also I can see that once it was revealed that Catra and Adora arent soulmates, it wouldnt feel super surprising for one of their soulmates to make an appearance. Let me know your thoughts!

Nextweek (or potentially later this week?) we will depart from the typical schedule and I will post chapter 10 because it feels mean to leave yall hanging like this for two weeks lol. So soon everything will be resolved!

As always, kudos and comments drive my writing. You can follow me on Twitter @esFlower1 and T umblr @esFlower .

Chapter 10

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora is a fucking wreck. It’s been two days since Catra left their house. The first, she mostly sat there going through the motions of cleaning and putting away groceries because it was something to do. By the time she finishes that, she calls Glimmer sobbing the full weight of what's at risk hitting her like a freight train.

Glimmer showed up at her house in the middle of the night and listened to Adora retell what happened. Today has mostly been Glimmer babysitting her, making sure she doesn't do something stupid.

"Have you heard from her?" Adora finally asks her best friend.

Glimmer winces patting Adora's knee over the blanket that she forced on Adora. "I heard from Scorpia. She's distraught. Obviously ." She supplies.

Adora snorts. She knows that Catra is distraught she watched her cry and flee their home like a crime scene.

"Fuck." Adora curses. "Glimmer , what the hell? This isn't fair ." She groans, not for the first time.

"I know Adora. But moping about how unfair it is, isn't going to make you suddenly figure your shit out." She points out, her tone exasperated.

She groans again. "I know you're right. I need to figure everything out."

The problem is she's barely processed everything that happened. She feels like she's at the cusp of a ledge and any sudden movement in any direction will send her careening down into the abyss.

"Okay . You have a soulmate and you have a girlfriend."Glimmer says slowly. "T wo different people."She tacks on. "What do you want Adora"?

"I want to not hurt anyone."It's her first thought and the one that's made moving forward most difficult.

"That's not about what you want, Adora. That's about other people." Glimmer observes.

Adora sighs. "What would you do"?She asks softly .

Glimmer grimaces. "Y ou know that's not a good comparison."

"T ell me anyway."

Glimmer sighs. "Y ou know Bow is it for me. I can't imagine a world where I wouldn't choose my soulmate. Even if I was with someone else~~it~~ wouldn't be a question."

"But you know Bow . This would be if you were strangers."

"Sure. But it's how I feel."She shrugs. "Y ou and I see things differently. So I'm not sure how helpful my thoughts are on this."

"Y eah, I get you."Adora runs her hands through her hair . "I love Catra so much~~I~~ don't want things to be over between us."She bites her lip. "D oes that make me selfish"?

Her brow furrows as she puts a hand on Adora's knee, patting it softly. "What about staying with Catra would make you selfish"?

"I guess~~Juliet~~ and I met against all odds and she probably expected to have a soulmate that is thrilled to find her . And I'm just—

Im not."She feels kind of guilty about it.

"Are you maybe scared? Y ou know, about what happened with your moms?"

Adora thinks about it, trying to sift through her emotions. "I dont think so."She doesnt feel the piercing fear that she used to feel when she thought of meeting her soulmate. "Did I tell you Ive been speaking more with my mom?"

"Y ou have mentioned that."

"W ell, weve had some conversations that have me thinking that a lot of what I attributed to soulmates was just her being unable to cope with the loss you know?"

"So you dont think it was because Mara was her soulmate?"

"I think it definitely made her feel more helpless."She allows. "But shes been doing a lot better now . Shes taken up gardening even."

She lets out a soft smile as she remembers her idle complaints about how Razs yard doesnt have a good place for blueberry bushes. Her friendship with Razseems to have inched her out of the well of depression Adora was unfit to help her mother out of when she was younger.

"My point is if something happened to Catra"—her throat closes up at the thought. "I dont know what Id do without her . So I guess with uliet, Im not worried about loving her too much and her dying or something awful happening because I think its life."

It took her a long time to come around to it, but the longer she and Catra were together the more she realized that there really isnt a reason why her loss would be less devastating than the loss of a soulmate. And that love is worth the risk.

"Alright. No part of you wonders about uliet?"

It's a harder question. "Y es."She finally admits. "I think it's hard not to wonder, I mean—she's my soulmate right?"

She tries to imagine if she'd met Juliet before she met Catra—when she'd been in a low place, longing for connection and feeling a bit lost with herself.

"I think it's normal to wonder ."Glimmer says slowly . "But do you think you'll regret it if you don't explore the possibility?"

Adora sighs. "I'll regret losing Catra more."Even if Catra and her break up down the road, she can't imagine regretting not chasing after Juliet now . What could she even look to build with Juliet if she's heartbroken over Catra? "I don't want anyone else Glimmer . Not even my soulmate."

Glimmer stares at her for a moment, her mouth softening around the edges. "That's pretty romantic."She comments.

Adora rolls her eyes. "W ell, still involves me hurting someone so Im not so sure about that."She bends her head to rest on her knees. "Juliet seems like a really nice person and I just—it's so weird it's like I *know* her. I don't want her to hurt."

Glimmer pulls Adora into a hug, patting her back. "I think that's not really under your control."She's using her mom voice, the sympathetic one she uses when Angel has broken a toy or skinned his knee.

"I know ."She knows, but she doesn't like it.

"Y ou seem more put together. Marginally."Glimmer says as she eyes Adora's raggedy pajamas and her dirty hair . "Why don't you take a shower and Ill leave you something to eat when you get out?"

Adora nods. She realizes she's taken Glimmer away from her family . "Thanks. Ill be alright just going to shower and try to go about my day."

Glimmer eyes her warily. "Okay . You sure?" She checks, searching Adora's gaze. "I can stay longer ."

"No, it's fine. Ill be fine." She waves her of f.

"What are you thinking of doing?" She asks.

Adora sighs. "I guess I know what I want to do I just have to figure out what to say." She bites her lip. "Catra also said she wanted space, I don't want to rush her ."

Glimmer nods understandingly. "Alright then. Let me or Bow know if you need anything." It's more of an order than an of fer but Adora smiles regardless.

"Y eah will do." She nods.

She lets Glimmer out and starts the shower, the water absolutely scalding when she gets in. She can't think of anything but how her skin aches and she can't breathe deeply because of the hot steam. It's better than the emotional ache she's been grappling with.

She hates that she even has to think this through, that somehow she has to make a choice that she never wanted to make. Catra is hurting and it's all her fault for picking the wrong time to do groceries.

She scrubs shampoo into her hair. No, she thinks, because Juliet moved into town—chances are high that Adora would have run into her eventually. To a certain degree, she's angry that she would have ended up in this position anyway.

But that's also stupid because it could be worse—Catra could have met her soulmate and Adora would be the one steeping in indecision. In a lot of ways, she wishes that had happened instead so that Catra wouldn't be waiting on her .

The water runs cold and she finally steps out, towel drying quickly and brushing her hair.

Her phone rings and her heart jumps thinking it might be Catra. She checks and her stomach lurches as she realizes who it is.

"Scorpia." She says tentatively.

"Adora, hi." Her voice is gentle and Adora is a little surprised.

"I figured you wouldn't want to talk to me, given everything." Hoping that it would prompt Scorpia to tell her why she was calling. Hoping that maybe Catra wants to reach out.

She hears Scorpia sigh. "You can't help who your soulmate is."

Her resigned tone makes the hair on Adora's neck stand on end. "I haven't done anything."

"I think that's kind of the point, Adora." Now her voice has a spark of that anger Adora had been expecting.

"She wanted space. That doesn't mean I've given up on us." She defends.

"Look, I'm not trying to get in the middle of this. And if Catra told you to give her space I get that but—" she cuts off, breathing harshly through her nose. "Not too much space. She deserves to know what you're going to do one way or the other."

"I'm not going to leave her hanging." Adora bites her lip. She wants to toe the line between not leaving Catra hanging and also not rushing into a decision—she wants Catra to believe her when she says she's thought things true, and frankly, Adora owes it to herself as well. "Tell her to come to the house tomorrow afternoon? Around three? If she's ready. If she wants more time she can let me know."

She doesn't know why she doesn't talk directly to Catra, but she feels like she might throw up if she does.

Scorpia is silent for a moment, considering Adora's words. "Okay, I'll let her know."

"Thanks."Adora lets out a sigh of relief.

"Be good to her alright?"No matter what."Scorpia sounds stern.

Adora wants to roll her eyes at the taller woman for assuming Adora would do anything less. "I always try ."Is what she ends up saying.

"Okay ,"Scorpia says before hanging up.

She putters around the house uselessly for twenty minutes. Every time she notices something of Catra's she feels a lump in her throat. There's a real chance that even when she tells Catra that she wants her that Catra won't want to be with her , knowing her soulmate is within easy reach. She tries to push the thought aside.

There's a knock on her door which she finds odd—she suspects maybe Glimmer ordered her a pizza. But when she opens the door she comes to find Netossa and Spinnerellla instead, both looking at Adora with soft sympathetic looks.

Adora is taken aback. "I didn't expect to see you both."She knows in all likelihood most of their friends know what's happening but she didn't expect anyone but Glimmer to show up at her door .

Netossa eyes her for a moment, probably taking in her big bathrobe and wet hair. "W ell, you seem like you could use a chat."

"Thanks—Im not quite sure what thatll do but I appreciate it."Adora lets them in and offers them her couch.

They both look at each other intently, holding hands. It leaves Adora confused, anticipating what they might say. "W e have some things we think youll find helpful."Spinnerella finally says.

Netossa sighs. "Y ou might not know this about us, but we aren't soulmates."

Adora's eyes widen as she takes a seat across from the couple. "What?"

"Yeah, we don't usually announce it I mean—you of all people know how that is."

"Yeah."Adora gives them a sympathetic glance.

"So, I met my soulmate but she passed. It was an untimely thing. I never thought I'd find anyone else."Netossa looks up at Spinnerella. "But when I found Spinny , I'd healed enough that I was ready to move on."

"I never met my soulmate,"Spinnerella says. "But I can't imagine I'd love anyone more than Netossa."

"I don't know if you it's right for you to go with Catra or your soulmate, but know that love isn't just about the mark you bore," Netossa says as she squeezes Spinnerella's hand.

"Wow."Adora looks between the women. "I never would have guessed."

"We don't really talk about it and we let people assume because it's easier."She explains.

Adora feels a tug of guilt—she definitely assumed that about them. "I'm sorry if you felt that I ever pressured you into keeping this to yourselves."

Spinnerella rolls her eyes. "It wasn't any one person, it's fine."She leans forward a bit, catching Adora's gaze. "To be honest we'd probably prefer to tell people in our own time if it becomes relevant. It isn't really anyone's business anyway ."

She nods immediately, knowing she wouldn't tell a soul. "Yeah, of course."

They look at each other again, the look lighter this time. "That's really all we had to say."

Adora lets the information sink into her head for a moment. "Can I ask you a question?" She looks at Spinnerella. "Do you regret not finding them? Your soulmate?"

Her face clears, a soft understanding left in place of attentiveness. "You're worried that Catra is going to want to find her soulmate?" She guesses.

"The thought has crossed my mind." She admits. "I've met Juliet, for better or for worse~~but~~ Catra..." She might feel dif ferently than Adora does~~.A~~dora might not be worth staying for the way Catra is.

Spinnerella shrugs. "It's hard to miss something you don't have, Adora. I've vaguely thought about my soulmate, I wonder what they did with their life, wish them well, but I've never had that deep wonder of where they are. Not the way I did before Netossa." She looks at her wife, eyes shining. "It's one of the ways that I knew Netty was for me."

"You need to make a decision, but you can't base it on shit you think everyone else will do. That's my two cents anyway." Netossa adds in.

She nods. "Okay." She clears her throat. "Thanks for sharing. Really. I know I want to stay with Catra but this puts a lot of things in perspective." She feels a little less odd, to not be the only one who is in love with someone the universe hasn't picked for her.

"No problem. We love you both and just want you to be happy, no matter what."

She feels a swell of gratefulness at her friends for being there for her in a way she didn't fully expect. "Love you both." She pulls them in for a hug before they leave.

She's left in an empty house again, stewing over questions she's answered, just hoping she'll get it right.

She ends up walking the neighborhood to clear her head. She kind of regrets not talking to Catra tonight, but she knows she shouldn't sneak up on the brunette after making plans to meet tomorrow. She still hasn't heard from her and she's not sure if she'll reach out before then. Adora doesn't let herself think of the possibility that Catra might not show.

Her feet keep her moving until the tips of her toes feel pinched in her shoes. When she stops she almost curses herself. Somehow, she's walked all the way to the Crimson Waste.

It isn't a far walk but it usually takes intention and effort to make it. She turns around to go back home when the door swings open and Catra is there. She ducks behind a car, feeling like the world's biggest fucking creep for showing up at her girlfriend's job when she asked for space.

Still, she can't help but look at her. Her heart pangs as she notices how tired Catra looks, shoulders slumped as she makes her way to her car. If it were someone else, she might think it's just a bad day at work but Adora knows better.

Sitting in the gravel behind a dirty car, she realizes that she's being an idiot. It makes her think of the night they met~~here~~ere Adora is, wandering lost, head stuck on the question of soulmates, and just looking at Catra makes her right herself.

It doesn't matter whether Catra wants her or what might be with Juliet~~that~~at isn't for her to decide. What matters is this, the way her heart leaps at the sight of Catra and urged her to go to her, to make sure that she's safe and happy.

She desperately wants to be Catra's, wants to gather her in Adora's arms and reassure her. She almost goes to do just that. But instead, she stays rooted in place, waiting until Catra backs out of her parking spot and drives away.

There's something else she has to do first.

Her leg is bouncing under the table and she tries to get it under control before the most familiar yet unfamiliar woman walks up to her. "Hey , how are you?" Adora starts nervously .

Juliet smiles easily , sitting down in the coffee shop Adora asked her to see her in this morning. "I'm great, I've been getting the hang of being in a new town. I really like it here though."

"That's awesome." She feels some warmth as she smiles at the other woman. There's something in her that tugs for her to get closer, but it's an errant instinct. "I'm really glad for you."

"Thanks." She looks at Adora knowingly . "But I don't think we're here to discuss my moving."

"Y eah." She feels nervous, not wanting to hurt this woman she doesn't know well. "So I ~~I~~ mentioned before, I have a girlfriend. And I'm not trying to presume about what you want out of a soulmate but I ~~I~~'m not looking for something romantic outside of what I have with Catra. I'm sorry if that's disappointing."

Juliet sighs but she doesn't seem very surprised. "I kind of figured from when we met."

Adora's eyes widen at Juliet's easy acceptance. "Oh. W ell, I just wanted to be upfront."

"I appreciate that. Honestly , it's a little disappointing but I'm mostly excited that I met you at all. It's so rare to meet after our marks are gone ~~it's~~ nice to put a face to the name so to speak." She explains.

Adora nods. She realizes she did also feel that way , even if she hadn't thought to put it into words. "Y eah, I understand that. It's interesting for sure."

"So how is Catra?" Juliet asks casually .

Adora sighs and thinks of the fact that she is seeing Catra for the first time in a few hours. "I'm not sure." She admits, still not okay with being a source of pain for Catra. "I'm hoping that we can talk it through."

"Well, you clearly love her. Many people drop everything to have a chance to be with their soulmate." Juliet's eyes look sad.

"I really am sorry." Adora can't help but apologize again.

"You know, strangely enough, I get it." Juliet sighs a faraway look in her eye. "I had a girlfriend a while ago—she was older than me." She chuckles a little. "When I turned twenty-nine she broke up with me, told me I need to look for my soulmate—she'd never met hers."

"Oh." Adora isn't quite sure what to say.

Juliet doesn't seem bothered. "I've never been as happy as I was with her. If you'd shown up on my doorstep when I was with her, I think I'd do the same thing you're doing now."

Adora laughs. What are the odds of that? "Well, I guess we are cut from the same cloth."

"Guess so." There's a pause and then Juliet reaches out a hand to tentatively touch Adora's shoulder. "Adora—I won't push but I hope we can be friends?"

She nods. "I'll think about it but I think I'd like that too." She pauses for a moment. "Maybe you should call your girl?"

Juliet freezes as if the thought had never occurred to her. "I don't know...it's been so long." She bites her lip, indecision overtaking her features. "What if she's moved on?"

Adora shrugs. "Only one way to find out."

"You know, you're right. Thanks, Adora."

When Juliet leaves she has a determined stride and something tells Adora she knows exactly what the taller woman would be doing later in the day.

She left the coffee shop feeling a little more at peace. Juliet doesn't seem heartbroken at any rate which eases her. Now she just has to offer herself to Catra and hope her girlfriend still wants her after all this.

Even though it's only one in the afternoon when she finishes chatting with Juliet, Catra's car is already in their driveway. She's not sure why Catra is here early but it's probably for the best—Adora was likely going to pace her house like a caged animal until three anyway. She's hoping Catra hasn't been waiting long.

She loiters in her own driveway for a moment, before she trudges up to her door. It feels a little silly, but she knocks to let Catra know she's coming in and then turns the key.

Catra is sitting on the couch, hands on her knees and eyes on the coffee table in front of her. When the door closes her eyes snap up to Adora.

She walks across the room but hesitates as she thinks about crossing the coffee table. Adora hates this feeling, the uncertainty of where she stands with Catra—and it has to be so much worse for her girlfriend.

"Catra." She finally says. "I missed you." She sounds vulnerable and weak because that's what she is.

She doesn't say anything, she's biting her lip as if to keep from crying.

"Okay. Um, I'm going to talk now I guess. You're going to listen to me?" She checks, making sure Catra is ready.

"Yes." It's the first word she lets out and it's so soft Adora wants to cross any distance that could ever exist between them, whether physical or emotional.

"Okay." She clears her throat. "I love you." She has to start with the most important thing first. She watches Catra's eyes widen at the declaration. "Maybe the universe is right and Juliet might be perfect for me somehow. But that doesn't matter to me." She nods to herself.

Catra gasps softly then presses her hand up to her mouth as if to stifle the sound. Adora continues.

"I fell in love with you and I honor that love, not because the universe said so, but because I chose to." Adora clenches her hands to keep them still at her side, trying to keep her breathing measured and her eyes on Catra. "Every day Catra, since I walked into that bar, I've been choosing you. And I don't want to stop."

"I talked with Juliet and she's a great person I could see how we could be good together but—" She searches for the right words to explain to Catra how she feels. "I don't want to let go of the best thing in my life for a shot at something that might be better."

Catra stares and stares some more, to the point where Adora fears she'll never speak to her again. "Adora, what does this mean?"

Adora crosses the distance between them, sitting on the coffee table so she's directly in front of Catra. She holds both of Catra's hands between her own.

"I want to stay with you. You're my girlfriend and I love you. *I want to stay*." She's realized in these last few days apart that it's as simple and as complicated as that.

"You're not just saying that because you're afraid?"

She shakes her head. "I've thought about this a lot Cat. From before I met Juliet. The truth is, it's not soulmates that can hurt you—being

close to people hurts. Like right now."She catches Catra's gaze. "You're hurting because you feel like you might lose me and I'm hurting because I'm worried about the same thing."

"So you want me to believe that you met your soulmate and you still want me?"Her disbelief is like a third person in the room, standing between them.

"Yes."She whispers desperately . "I need you to trust me when I tell you that I know what I want and it's you."She knows that even the doubt that Adora might falter is enough to blow their relationship apart if Catra lets it.

"And you won't change your mind?"Her eyes are teary again, but it isn't the heartbroken look she'd given Adora the last time they spoke.

"I love you so so much Catra. I know that."She af firms again. She can't tell the future but as far as what she wants, her future is Catra.

Adora lets out a small grunt as Catra lurches into her arms wrapping her arms tightly. "I love you too."She whispers into Adora's neck. She takes a deep breath. "If you say that you're sure then I'm willing to trust you."She moves her head so that she's looking Adora in the eyes again. "Doesn't mean I won't need reassurances sometimes."

Adora pulls her in tightly, the relief making her body sag onto Catra's. "You can have whatever you want, Cat."She promises.

"Can I have a kiss?"

Adora laughs. "You don't even have to ask."

She ducks down and the kiss is beyond charged, too much teeth and heavy breathing but Adora wasn't sure she'd ever get another so she doesn't give a fuck.

She holds Catra close, breathes her in, and can't fight the tears of relief.

"I don't want to ever lose you," Adora admits softly. "Can I show you?" Her hand traces down Catra's side, one of her fingers dipping under her shirt.

Catra nods and kisses her deeply. Adora lifts Catra up, and she wraps her legs around her torso. She blindly walks them toward their bedroom, with the hope that she'll show Catra her love and devotion in a way that's undeniable.

She expects to wake up snuggled in with Catra and honestly, she doesn't expect to leave her bed for the rest of the day. But instead, she wakes up and the bed is not as warm as it should be.

"Adora? The fuck did you do to me? This isn't funny!" Catra whines.

She props herself up on her elbows, squinting as she realizes that Catra is hollering from the bathroom. She doesn't sound truly upset and Adora is too sleepy to decipher what her girlfriend is yelling about without context. She pads over to the bathroom and sees Catra watching herself in the mirror.

She smirks at that. "Is it a hickey? I can leave more if you want." She wraps her arms around her waist and Catra melts back into her. Adora still hasn't come down from their physical reunion the night before. She'd touched every inch of Catra and felt more sure than ever that staying together is the only path forward that she wants.

Catra has a cute determined little furrow on her brow. "No, but whatever ink you used isn't coming off." She rolls her eyes and turns.

Adora checks out her torso before she locks in on Catra's shoulder. She takes a step back so she can get a full look. Before, where there was just skin, now there's a mark Adora's never seen before. It looks a little like Catra's soul mark, but different.

"Catra I didn't draw that on you." She says slowly. She then notices that Catra is frozen staring at Adora now. "What?"

"Adora. Your arm." She says urgently, voice half strangled.

"Huh?" Adora looks at the mirror and the same mark is on her shoulder.

"Is that—" Adora stares and she feels the warmth of the soul mark because it can't be anything else can it? pulsing on her arm. Instead of the pain, it's a pleasant warmth that heats her whole body. "Are we—"

"Adora, I've never heard of this happening." The awe and wonder in Catra's voice distracts Adora from her thoughts as she centers on her girlfriend again.

"Maybe sometimes the universe lets you choose," Adora says softly, wrapping her arms around Catra. She traces her hand over Catra's mark, marveling at how it looks like a perfect mix of their old marks. It looks like the mask Catra had, but instead, it was winged, the wings looking like the heart-like shape that used to be Adora's mark. "I don't think I could love anyone more than you."

She feels like the love she has for Catra just can't be contained inside her body. Maybe this new mark is a manifestation of that.

"I love you too Dor. So much." She presses a soft kiss to her lips.

Adora looks at the mark again and she feels tears well up in her eyes. She laughs as she wipes her eyes. "I'm sorry, I'm being silly."

"Not at all. Don't be mean to my soulmate." Her voice is teasing but her eyes are soft as she says the words aloud.

Adora lifts Catra up, enjoying the surprised little squeak she releases when she does. "We are going back to bed." She informs her soulmate dutifully, a huge grin across her face.

Catra rolls her eyes but she's smiling too. "Whatever shall we do there?"

"Well, Im going to make my best octopus interpretation while I cuddle you, and then well see."She decides as she pads them over .

Catra shakes her head and laughs. "Sounds like a plan."

Adora lays Catra down carefully and does as promised, pulling her into her chest. "You know Id choose you, mark or no mark."She murmurs lowly. She doesnt want there to be any doubt in Catras mind.

Catra is relaxed in her arms, a lazy smile on her face. "Obviously Dr . You just did that."She leans up to look at Adoras face. "You know Id do the same, right?"

"I know ."She nods, burying her nose in Catras hair .

"I was so worried the whole time we were apart. I didnt think there was a way youd choose for us to stay together ."She admits softly . "I just couldnt unsee what happened to me before I guess."

Her heart breaks in her chest for Catra, even with their newfound joy . "I always knew Catra. I just didnt want you to think I didnt think it through or that I would take it back. And you asked for space I didnt want to pressure you either."Adora assures.

"The mark is nice but I dont need it,"Catra says as she leans up and kisses Adora fully. "All I need is you."

Adora doesnt bother responding with her words, instead kissing her soulmate. She couldnt agree more.

Chapter End Notes

AHHH and its a wrap!I STRUGGLED with how I wanted to end this had three different endings but ultimately I am 100% sure that THIS was the right ending. It fits with the message I wanted for this story and it was true to what I wanted to express.

That being said, I did write an alternative ending where they are soulmates from the getgo, and you can read that in this Tumblr Post

I am open to your thoughts! Seems like there was a split between folks who expected one of their soulmates might appear and folks who were taken by surprise.

In terms of epilogue, I have kicked around a few ideas (Lonnie resurfacing, the friends reaction to Catra and Adoras mark appearing, a one-shot centered on Casta/Juliet) but Im not 100% sure I will do anything. Let me know if something jumps out to you on that front.

I also know I have been very short in my authors notes recently and its mostly because I am very very busy at work. Thanks for all the support and love yall have given not only this story but almost everything I write. I really couldnt write for a better fandom.

As always, kudos and comments are super appreciated. You can follow me on Twitter @ResFlower1 and Tumblr @ResFlower.

Next Week: We are going to have chapter 4 of Secrets are the Enemy! This will be the new "anchor" fic, so it will be getting updates every other week and Battle Cry and Paradigm Shift will get updates once a month-ish. (There also might be 2 multichapter WIPs waiting in the wings but that will be for yall to dicuss with 2023 Res lol)

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!